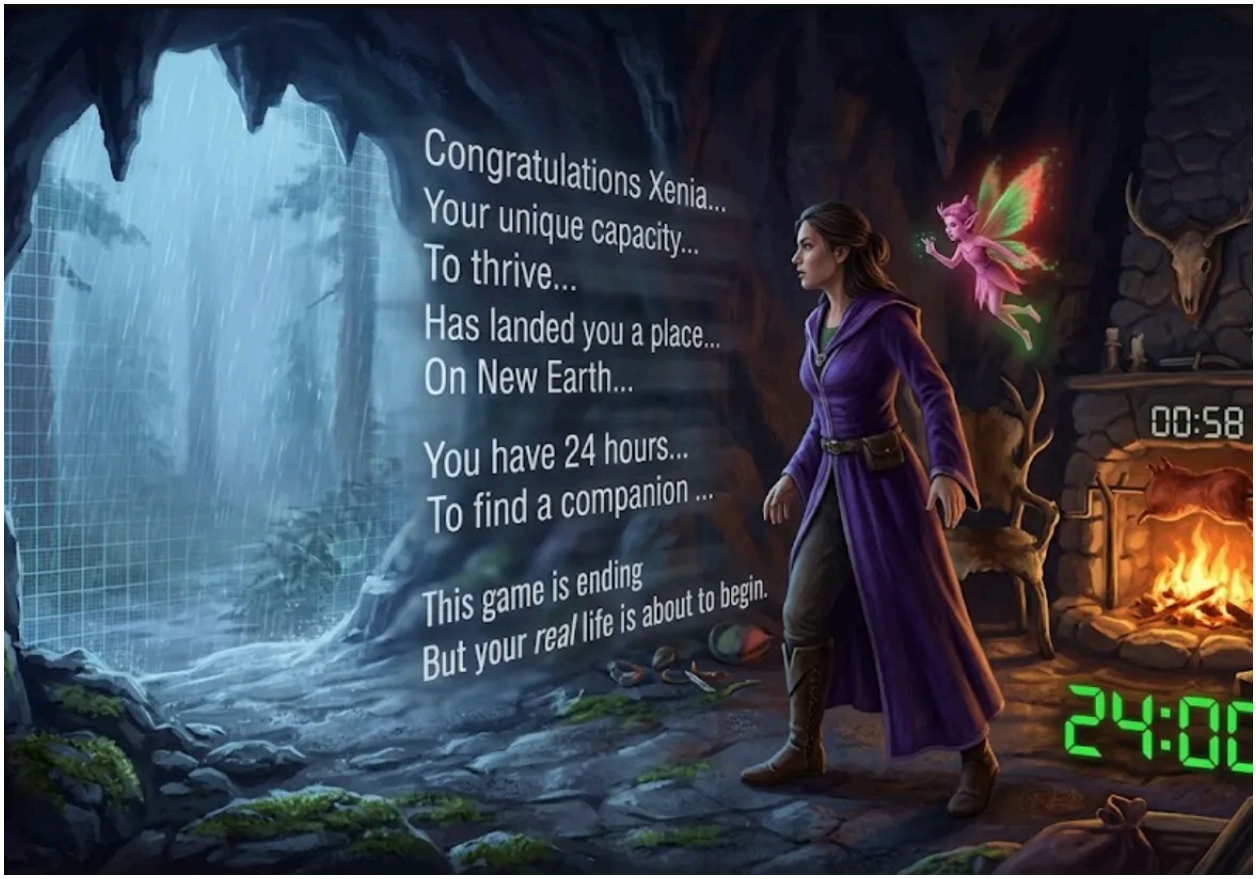
1- First Contact
Mystic Depths - Inside Hyperspear (Inside SS Hyperspear) Outside The Hyades Cluster
8-12-2199
POV Xenia:



Purple, vitality-draining, magic crackles from my outstretched palm, blasting the raggedly clothed Rhinoceros Humanoid in front of me and sending him thudding to his knees.

“Oof,” he groans, as his matte black Tec 9 pistol clatters to the stone floor of my cave lair.

Rhino guy glances above my head at my vitals display reaching for his fallen gun as he snickers, “Looks like you’re outta magi—oof”

With a swift kick of my dragon leather boot, I knock him against the mossy cave wall before dropping to a knee, retrieving his gun and releasing a volley of bullets into his right shoulder.

Cartoonish blood spurts from his wounds as two of his last three life hearts go white.

“Just give back the ham you stole.” I demand, ejecting the Tec 9’s clip and tossing it on to an antler and bearhide chair beside my kitchen hearth.

A flash of lightning illuminates the entrance of my cave, momentarily, exposing the pixelated grid that encapsulates our endless redwood forest world. Outside, glistening, sapphire

raindrops fall at the same steady pace they've been falling, from noon until midnight, every-single, soggy-sock day for the last two centuries.

I turn as a clap of thunder rattles the jars of herbs on the wood hutch beside me.

When I refocus my gaze on Rhino Man, his pupils have split into three blue scrolling blips, indicating that he's navigating through his inventory menu.

His eyeballs re-appear as a raw, bloody pig haunch materializes by his hooves.

"I've got a family to feed." Rhino guy's ears flatten contritely.

Rolling my eyes, I wave dismissively towards the cave entrance.

"Glitch!" He grumbles as he turns, hobbling off into the soggy coastal forest.

I touch the ham and it disappears, materializing a moment later on a large spit above a flickering fire in my hearth. I breathe in the smell of caramelizing fat as a sixty second timer appears over the slowly turning spit, ticking down the seconds until the smell of food will be replaced by the feeling of satiation.

"I miss chewing food." I sigh as I slump into my arm chair, my mind reeling through memories of my old life as a naive Neighborhoods NPC. Back when I still believed I was a real girl in a real, chew-food-while-you-chew-the-fat kinda world.

My roommate, a flying pink pixie named Fayezilla, flutters out of a hollow gourd that dangles from a stalactite above me. "I miss being able to leave our stupid cave without everyone grabbing at me." The pixie glows red, vibrating indignantly. "Hairy beasts dragging me across their disgusting snouts to ease —their— anxiety." Her high pitched voice is shriller than normal.

Fayezilla glides down to my shoulder, tracing her bare toes across the purple velvet collar of my mage robe. "My sister, who lives in a children's fairytale game, said they're breeding the Faye like livestock and smuggling fairies and dust into every game world in Hyperspear."

She drops to a seat, settling into my clavicle. "It's very upsetting. two-hundred-year-old children snorting dust and caging fairies."

My hearth dings and the ham and its sixty-second timer blip out of existencel as I feel a warm satisfaction in my stomach. Wrenching off my boot, I twiddle my bare toes, dumping a pile of gleaming jewels onto the floor.

Fayezilla springs off my shoulder and swandives towards an oval cut ruby.

Delicately extending her index finger, she touches the jewel, her wings fluttering excitedly as the halo of shimmering dust around her turns a vibrant pink. Her magic bar fills to 100% as the gem disappears.

The glistening fairy launches herself up towards my eagerly flared nostrils, shimmying around my face in one of her famous "thank you fairy much laps" that leave my brain effervescing from her magical dust.

Hovering by my ear, Fayezilla lowers her voice. "That boxing Kangaroo from the marketplace said he found a backdoor to get into Neighborhoods, maybe we should check it out."

Sitting up in my chair, I shake my head, waking myself from the dust stupor. "The last time Jenna messaged me, she said things in the Neighborhoods gameworld are pretty bleak too."

Stooping to scoop up the rest of my jewels, I feel the familiar electric shiver of a glitch running up my spine. The rain falls silent. The world blurs and then, unexpectedly, white text begins scrolling across my entire field of view:

Congratulations Xenia...

Your unique capacity...

To thrive...

Has landed you a place...

As one of my Hopefuls

On New Earth...

You have 24 hours...

To find a companion ...

This game is ending

But your *real* life is about to begin.

As the message disappears, and the world un-blurs, a green twenty-four hour countdown clock begins ticking in my top right peripheral: **23:59:59.**

"Xenia!" Fayezilla is hovering directly in front of me, snapping her tiny fingers in my face as I blink back into awareness.

"Whoa, that was crazy," I gasp.

"What happened?" The faye's eyes are wide with concern.

"You didn't get a message?" I cock my head. "About the game ending?"

"Game —ending? What does that even mean?" Fayezilla flutters backwards.

"Let's go to the marketplace and find that Kangaroo you were talking about." My pulse surges as I'm flooded with a hopeful excitement. "I need to see my friend Jenna."

Two Hours Later

Rain pelts us as we approach the muddy bluegrass meadow where recently killed Mystic Depth residents respawn. The crack-of-a-whip sound of re-enlivening NPCs snaps through the air like a lasso show and my skin crackles with rolling glitches.

Some of the burlap-clad respawns wander towards waiting friends and family. Others trollop over to the market stalls where feral rats dart between crowded rows of vendors selling

whatever scratches your itch: everything from broken weapons and ale to caged beasts and fairy dust.

A humanoid Bloodhound in a rumpled beige trench coat, collar popped to his floppy ears, catches my eye from behind a redwood stump full of fairy dust paraphernalia. Taking a deep sniff in my direction he eyes me knowingly.

"Hey kid," his gravely voice beckons to me as he reaches a paw inside his detective-style coat, pulling out a dingy plastic Dustbuster. I squint at the device. The word Blaster has been sharpied over the word “Buster” and a plastic tube has been duct taped to the side.

"Wanna take a bite out of reality?" He winks, flicking the on switch.

The modified exhaust line lets out a high-pitched whine accompanied by a muffled barrage of slurs and insults from inside the plastic housing.

“Quiet down in there!” the bloodhound grumbles, shaking the device violently as it sprays a glittering cloud of pink dust into the damp air.

Between my shoulder blades, I feel Fayezilla shake with rage as she buckles herself into her combat harness inside the metal case where she hides under my robes.

Turning away from the gruff dog man, I continue to weave through the throngs of potato-sack-wearing shoppers until we reach a sagging boxing ring with a faded red banner across its base: “Out Box Treasure the Kangaroo and Win a Box of Treasure.”

2 - **The Countdown**

Neighborhoods - Inside Hyperspear (Inside SS Hyperspear) Outside The Hyades Cluster
8-12-2199
POV Jenna -



“Paisley,” I sigh, “The re-spawn marketplace is only ten miles away, why not just drive your great grand-dad’s truck?”

I rest my wrinkled hand on the pink, bedazzled Mac10 machine gun that my great-granddaughter is pulling from the macrame side holster I made her.

Her leather jacket groans as she steps back, gently tugging the gun from my grip. “You’re so old fashioned GG-Jenna,” Paisley giggles, swinging the Mac10 towards me. “Why don’t you come with?” She tongues her lip ring, rocking back on the heel of her hightop sneaker.

“Ditch your geriatric supper club for once and lets hit up a *dance* club instead.” She shimmies towards me.

Chuckling, I shake my head, spilling my salt and pepper locks across my face. “I want to see how far I can go this time before I naturally re-spawn.”

“Sounds like a drag.” Paisley raises her gun to her temple then pauses “Need anything from the market?”

“Well…” I click my tongue. “I am low on sugar.”

“I gotchu.” She pulls the trigger.

I turn away, my ears ringing, as my sweet great-grandaughter’s beautiful face explodes into a thick red mist that splatters across the floor.

Shaking my head at the bloody bits of skull on our white living room rug, I fight my impulse to grab a mop. I know by now that the stains will pixelate away before they set on the fabric, but the sight still stays with me longer than I'd like.

"Was that Paisley heading out?" My husband myka brushes his sandy gray locks away from his face as he trudges in from the den, "I wish she'd put a silencer on that thing."

His green, couderoy trousers swish as he strides over, planting a soft kiss on my lips.

I wrap my arms around Myka's neck gazing into his sparkling hazel eyes as Paisley's abandoned body and associated gore pixelate out of existence.

Untangling myself from Myka, I turn towards the pile of laundry behind me and lay one of his beige work shirts across the ironing board. Lifting the hot iron, I let out a lavender-scented blast of steam.

As I begin pressing his shirt, a sudden, rapid-fire clucking sound comes through the baby monitor on the coffee table. I'd originally set up the monitor so I could listen to the pleasant chatter of our front yard chickens, but their natural predatory alarm has been an added bonus.

"Are you expecting anyone?" Myka eyes me curiously, tip-toeing towards the front curtain. Before he can reach it, I hear our dog Pajama's bark-translating collar enthuse: "Xenia! Xenia is Coming!"

"You're confused old man?" Myka scratches our two-hundred-year-old mutt between his perpetually five-year old ears. "Xenia doesn't live in our world anymore."

"Xenia!" Pajama bounces on his front paws "Xenia — Out Front!"

"The collar has been acting up lately." I set down the iron. "It's probably Cheryl from next door wanting some fresh eggs."

Myka pulls the lace curtains aside and his jaw drops. "I think the collar's actually fine!"

Hustling to the front door, he unbolts our lock, removing the door bar, before stepping aside to reveal my oldest friend in the Hyperspear Universe.

Xenia Chloros, looking not a day over twenty five, tips her straw cowgirl hat towards me, unleashing a cascade of dark curls as she bows.

"Holy wow!" I rush across the room to the front door. "Is it really you?" I giggle, throwing my arms around her.

"I'm just as real as any other NPC inside this game console," Xenia winks.

Outside, I hear a neighbor shout in the distance: "Don't forget the milk," as a gunshot rings though the culdesac.

"I guess you Neighborhoods NPCs figured out the fast way to the market too." Xenia nods towards the neighbor's body as she follows me inside.

"I can't say I love the idea of treating a gun like a taxi service, but, there's just so many people and so much traffic everywhere." I guide our guest into the kitchen, gesturing for her to take a seat at the table Myka had carved for my hundredth birthday.

"Its the same in Mystic Depths." Xenia frowns as she slides into a creaking, wicker chair. "I can't even get a fresh kill home to my lair without having three mobs of Orcs try to rob me."

"So is that why you're here? You're fleeing from Mystic Depths monsters?" I ease myself into a seat across from Xenia.

"You didn't get the system message from Hyperspear?" Xenia's eyes bore pleadingly into mine.

Pursing my lips I shake my head. "Sorry, I have no idea what you're talking about."

My heart sinks as Xenia relays the cryptic message she'd received.

"Have you slept?" Myka slinks over setting a cup of tea in front of Xenia as he slides into a chair beside me.

Leaning towards him, Xenia rests her elbows on the table. "I slept a bit when I was inside the magic kangaroo's magic pouch ch ch ch ch—"

My friend's entire torso pixelates, static popping violently in the air around her.

"Whoa!!" Myka and I throw our chairs back, leaping away from the sparks.

Pajama, who had been sleeping under the table, springs up, hackles raised as he growls accusingly at Xenia.

"I've never seen a glitch that intense before." I gasp.

Suddenly, the popping stops and Xenia re-solidifies. "I have more details." She utters, gesturing for us to sit down.

I slide into a seat across from Xenia while Myka takes a step back, crossing his arms as he leans against the wall, pajama curling up by his feet.

Lowering her eyes, Xenia clears her throat. "So I guess, Hyperspear found a planet that it's calling New Earth… and so, uhm, I guess it wants to upload a group of NPCs that its calling The Hopefuls into physical, real-world, bodies there, uhm, to save resources." Xena stammers, "it's going to archive all the game worlds and unchosen NPCs."

Myka steps away from the wall, casting a heavy stare at Xenia. "So you've been chosen as a Hopeful and Jenna and I are getting spun down," he accuses.

"Why are you looking at *me* like that?" Xenia jumps up from her chair, glaring at Myka. "I didn't ask for any of this."

"So why are you here then?" Myka asks coldly.

"Hyperspear told me to select a companion, so I came for Jenna," Xenia blurts.

"What about Myka?" I rise to my feet, my eyes wide as the idea of existing in a world without my husband of two hundred years smashes into my chest like a sledge hammer.

"Sorry friend." Xenia ducks her head. "I know this is upsetting news." She lifts her eyes to mine. "Once things are up and running on New Earth I'm sure we can find a way to bring your whole family there."

Before I can respond, a high-pitched barrage of chicken clucks blares through the flock monitor in the living room.

Xenia goes rigid. Cocking her ear towards the ceiling, her face drops. "Sounds like there's some big helicopters headed this way."

"It's probably just my GGD Paisley coming back from the market." I shrug as the distant oscillating pulse of chopper blades grows louder.

We all listen in still silence to the approaching aircraft until it comes to hover directly over the house, rattling the windows.

"Duck and Cover! Duck and Cover!" PJ's collar blares as he zooms into the front room, wriggling under the couch.

The rest of us dive under the kitchen table, bracing ourselves.

BOOM! something thuds onto our roof and I hear the chopper's metal frame whine before it careens into a neighbor's house, releasing a hot percussive blast of energy that sends a rain of plaster down from the ceiling and shatters our windows.

“GG Myka!” Squinting through the, now tattered, front curtains I catch a glimpse of Paisley precariously clinging to the rain gutters above the front porch.

“Paisley’s home! Paisley! Home!” Pajama’s collar enthuses as he wriggles out from under the couch, his tail swishing wildly while he prances in circles in front of the window.

Coughing, I scramble out from under the table as the sound of a second helicopter begins to vibrate the debris on the floor.

Beside me, Xenia extends her arm towards my great-granddaughter, shouting. “Lasso Target”.

Nothing happens.

“Magic doesn’t work in this game world, Chosen One.” Myka shoulder-checks Xenia, hustling past her into the front room.

“Right, I guess I need to get used to doing things the old fashioned way.” Xenia lets her arm fall lamely to her side.

Myka, steps through a broken window bounding across the front porch and sweeping Paisley up in his arms.

When he steps back in, setting Paisley on her feet, she rushes over to me, Pajama trailing behind.

“A riot broke out at the market.” She shouts over the din of the second helicopter.

“They’re saying we only have a few hours until Hyperspear shuts down all its game worlds.” She blinks away a tear

Air wooshes through the house sending dust and debris flying as the second helicopter touches down in the cul de sac.

A tall man and hulking dog hop out, striding casually toward the front porch while Pajama launches into another barking fit, his collar spewing expletives at the strangers.

“You can’t just go stealing folks' helicopters every time someone cries doomsday.” the man’s cold booming voice chastises.

The stranger’s dog goes rigid, pinning its front leg to its torso.

“Well what do ya know!” The stranger laughs. “Arrow here thinks you have a fairy in there.” He tussles the dog's ears raising his AR.

“Your dog’s mistaken.” Myka steps in front of Paisley and me corralling us back into the kitchen, as the man perforates the wall of the front room with bullets.

In one swift motion, Xenia grabs the meat cleaver from my butcher block and charges toward the front window.

As the black-clad stranger eases his leg through the window, Xenia launches herself at him, raising the knife above her head. With a single, swift hacking chop she cleaves his leg off at the hip.

The leg drops to the floor, spinning like a pinwheel as cartoonish blood gushes in all directions.

Xenia hacks off the man's head before turning towards his snarling dog. “Not the dog Xenia.” I bury my face in Myka’s chest, stroking Pajamas ears while I try to ignore the sounds of hacking and yelping coming from the front porch.

“All good now!” Xenia boasts, glass crunching under her boots as she hoists herself back in through the front window.

“Hellloo Pretty Stranger!” Paisley coos, sidling over to my friend.

“Thank you so much for handling that bad guy.” Paisley grabs Xenia’s hand forcing her into an enthusiastic handshake. “I’m Paisley.”

I stare incredulously at my pandering progeny while I try to think of the most convincing way to tell my dearest friend that she needs to run away to New Earth with my husband.

“You don't wanna take me. Take Myka instead.” I plead.

Suddenly, Xenias’ back rumbles violently and a red, pulsating fairy bursts out from her shirt collar soaring into the air above her head.

“See, this Jenna person doesn’t even want to go with you!” The disgruntled fairy sasses out her hip, pointing an accusing finger at Xenia. “What better companion could you possibly have on New Earth than the most sought after being in all of Hyperspear.” The fairy pouts, sending a cloud of sparkling dust into the air around her. ”What can this old hag over here,” the rude pixie eyes me disdainfully, “possibly offer that I can’t?”

“You need to take Myka!” I blurt.

Xenia shakes her head. “It has to be you, Jenna.” Setting the bloody meat cleaver on the kitchen counter, she steps towards me. “The message said I was chosen because of my ability to thrive.” She rests her hand on my shoulder. “You’re the one who taught me how to thrive.”

For hours, we pitch our cases: me pleading for Xenia to take Myka who I know will be the most useful while Paisley and Fayezilla advocate for themselves.

When red sixty second count down clocks appear above Myka, Paisley and Fayezilla’s heads, Xenia hasn’t budged on her decision. Glancing up I see I have a countdown clock too, but mine is green like Xenia’s.

Sobbing, I throw myself into Myka’s arms and squeeze my eyes shut while Pajama nuzzles his face between us.

“Jenna leaks sad water.” Pajama’s collar laments.

“Hold me when you go.” Paisley pleads to Xenia. “Maybe you can bring me with you too.” She locks her legs and arms around Xenia.

Gunshots and explosions ring through the streets outside.

I bury my face deeper into my husband’s shoulder, hoping maybe I’ll suffocate and respawn and I won’t have to wake up in some new world where he no longer exists.

Opening my eyes, I take a last look at the world I’ve inhabited for two centuries.

Xenia is cradling Paisley under one arm.

Four seconds.

Fayezilla is slowly backing away from Xenia’s face.

Three seconds.

Fayezilla lays flat in the air, her fist extended in front of her.

Two seconds.

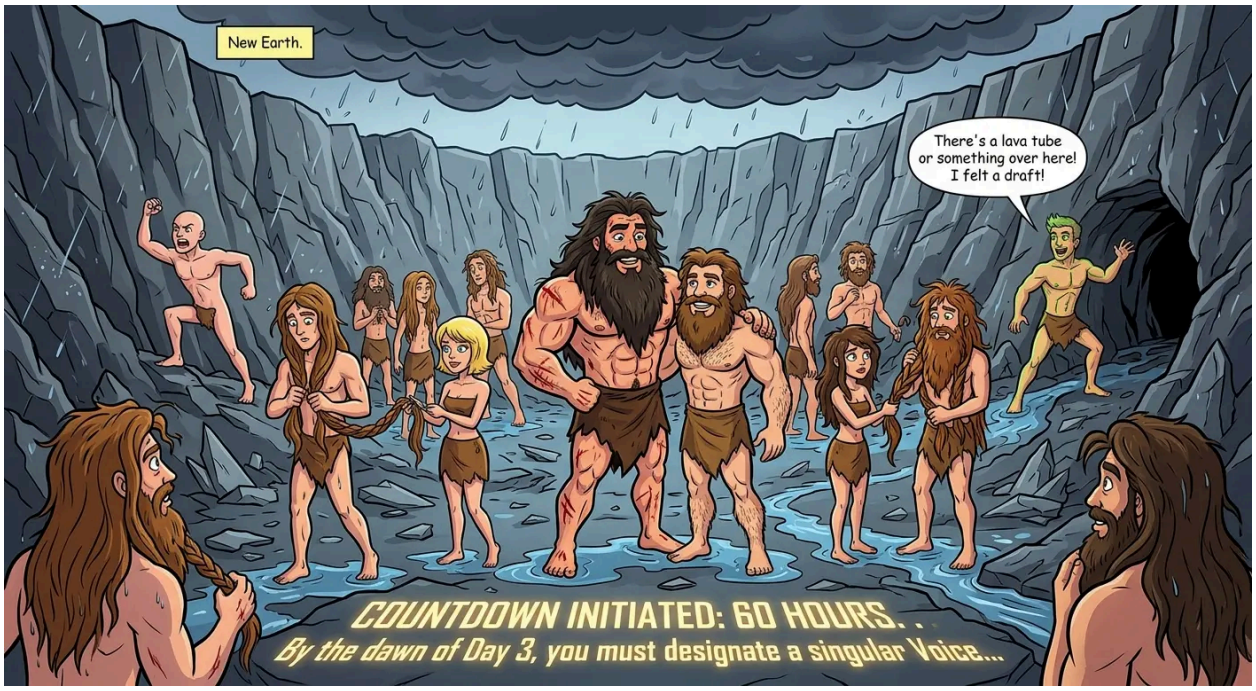
A sonic burst booms from the spot where Fayezilla had been.

One second.

Xenia’s head jolts back, the pink fairy’s heels protruding from her mouth.

Then everything is bright white, searing pixelations of pain…

3 - The Hopefuls
New Earth - Hopeful Mountain Top
01-01-0000
POV Diego



Bright White… Searing Pixelations of Pain… My heartbeat thumps in my chest, blood rushes through dry veins, igniting my bare nerves in fiery pain as they sizzle to life.

A cacophony of anguished screams and groans erupt around me and I hear myself join in, as skull-splitting pain flares through my brain. My head throbs as two hundred years of archived memories are seared into my supple brain tissue.

Helpless and naked, I collapse into a ball on the jagged, hard surface beneath me, pinning my palms against my ears. For countless agonizing minutes, I jerk and writhe on a floor that seems to be made of shattered glass and hair. And then suddenly it stops.

My headache subsides and the vibrance of New Earth's sounds and smells overwhelms my senses. The acrid stench of sulfur and ash sting my nostrils as layers of sound bombard my ears – people moaning, the sharp, squawking caws of distant birds, a low pulsating rumble that hums across the shattered surface below me. I tip my head back and blink my eyes open, admiring the vast cerulean sky —until I turn my gaze towards the warm light of the single star above. The light pierces my eyeballs.

I throw my bloody scratched arm across my face, shielding my fragile retinas from the blazing sunlight. Bright spots continue to dance across my vision even with my eyelids snapped shut. I chastise myself for not remembering that corporeal beings can be blinded just by looking at their star.

My tongue feels like a dry thumb as I lick my cracked, calloused lips and cautiously blink my eyes open again. As the world comes into focus, I realize I'm at the bottom of some sort of

volcanic crater: about thirty feet deep and fifty feet across. Surrounding me are several dozen naked, fit, extremely long-haired, young adult humans.

Pressing into the shards of rock on the crater floor, I attempt to stand, but my toes tangle in some coarse fiber, and I yelp in surprise as I crash down hard, grinding my hands and knees into the sharp floor.

“Gwwahh!” I hear a slightly off version of my voice bellow as pinpricks of pain radiate through my entire face. Looking down, I realize my toes are tangled in my impressively long, thick, beard. As I untangle my beard, I catch sight of the five foot long mane of hair draping over my beef-cake shoulders and my eyes land on a familiar figure sitting beside me. My son and traveling companion, Luke.

A wide grin spreads across my face as a yeti-bearded, twenty-five-year-old version of my two-hundred-year-old boy toddles towards me, six feet of dark locks trailing behind him.

Youthful jubilance gushes through me as I awkwardly tackle Luke, pulling him into a loose side embrace.

“Dad!” Luke bellows, exuberantly, flexing his forearms. “Look how freakin’ swole we are!”

“And these ladies” He nudges me with his elbow, gesturing around the crater where the other Hopefuls are now sharing their first moments on New Earth with their own —hairy, naked— companions.

“Look at that!” I marvel, stooping to the crater floor, I pick up a two-foot-long, black wing feather that looks like it’s from a massive chicken. I twirl the feather between my fingers as my mind flicks back two hundred years to my first, narrowly won battle as an NPC — against a giant black rooster.

Re-focusing on the present moment, I turn to Luke. “I can’t wait to get out of this hole and see what other kinds of flora and fauna might be here!”

“Aww, Dad,” Luke snickers, “you couldn’t even make it five minutes on New Earth without thinking about gardening.”

“Yeah well,” I guffaw, “I guess that’s why Hyperspear asked me to come here and why you’re just my plus one.” I clap Luke on the back, playfully.

“Are you kidding me?!” An outraged voice jars me from the father-son moment.

A few yards away, a completely hairless man pumps his fist at the sky as he screams: “You made me bald here too?!”

On the other side of the crowd a woman’s voice wails: “My Wings? Where are my wings?”

“I can’t use magic!” A deep-voiced man grumbles.

“I can’t access a game menu!”

“Why are we all humans?”

“My hunger level is ten!”

Complaints swirl all around as a short blond lady sidles over to me, tipping her head toward the bald man as she grumbles: “That gleaming headed guy over there really shouldn’t complain. It’ll take me an hour just to braid this mane I’ve got.”

The Gleam casts a biting look our way before stomping indignantly off towards the shaded crater wall.

“I like the way your head gleams, babe”, a red-haired lady coos, hurrying after him.

“Jenna!” A voice calls out from the middle of the crowd, making my ears perk as ancient memories of old friends begin to surface.

“Jen–na why aren’t you answering me?” The familiar voice calls.

“Xenia?” The name comes out of my mouth before I even remember how I know the dark-maned damsel striding through the crowd. Then an epiphany goes off in my brain. Two centuries ago, before The Great Provincial Placement locked us into different game worlds, Xenia and Jenna had been two of my closest friends.

My heart flutters as warm, ancient memories of shared meals and hard won battles resurface.

“Diego?” The two girls chime in unison.

Beside me, Luke turns to face my approaching friends. “Are these the girls that…” His gaze settles on Xenia’s chest. “... the girls that helped save me when that Darcy lady kidnapped me?”

Stopping a couple feet away, Jenna shyly arranges her hair to cover her lady parts, offering Luke and me a weak smile and an unenthusiastic wave.

I tuck my own long locks between my legs as Xenia trudges over to Luke.

“Can this be baby Luke?” She narrows her eyes at my son. “ –oggling my boo–.”

Xenia’s voice suddenly cuts off, her left eye twitching wildly as her shoulders go rigid.

Luke steps back, shooting Jenna and me a concerned look.

Squeezing her eyes shut, Xenia crosses her arms over her chest stammering: “I think some part of my brain is still bootloading.”

“I haven’t felt any glitches yet.” Jenna mumbles. “I thought we were supposed to be leaving those behind.”

The sunlight dims and I squint up at the clouds beginning to form in the sky above our crater.

“Your glitchiness may be the least of your worries.” I frown. “If it starts storming, this crater’s going to fill up like a bucket.

Jamming my index finger and thumb in my mouth I let out a piercing whistle. The sound reverberates around the crater silencing the grumbling Hopefuls.

“Hey folks!” I clear my throat. “Lets not forget we’re not only lucky to be here, but we also don’t have a choice.”

My lacerated feet sting with each step as I crunch across the crater floor, pacing amongst my fellow Hopefuls. “We need to work together and try to stay positive.”

The crowd makes room for me as I stride towards the bald man who's making a bloody mess of his hands attempting to get purchase on a horizontal crack in the rock wall while his companion gnaws at a strand of her hair. “I want to make him gloves.” She pauses, staring up at me helplessly.

Stooping, I dig through the chunks of jagged rocks by my feet until I find a cracked, jagged chunk of fossilized lighting, fulgurite. Using the jagged edge, I saw off a thick, five-foot long lock of my own hair and hand it to the woman.

Turning back to the crowd I cup my hands around my mouth. “Folks, our fellow Hopefuls over here have the right idea—” I tip my face up towards the clouds. “—we need to get out of this dang hole!”

Jenna, careful to keep the bulk of hair tucked between her legs, pulls out a strand of her

chestnut locks and slinks towards me. “Maybe we can make ropes from our hair and then if someone here’s really good at climbing they can get up there and we can pull ourselves out. Take my hair,” she offers, smiling shyly.

Everyone murmurs in approval.

“Whoa, Dudes, Check this Out!” A green-eyed adonis shouts from the back of the crowd, “There’s a lava tube or something over here. I think I felt a draft. Maybe we can get out of this dungeon pit if we go this way.”

My stomach clenches at the mention of a dungeon. I spent two hundred years tending digital crops inside a cozy farming sim—a game originally designed for toddlers and bored housewives. I’m eager for adventure, but my last experience in a dungeon world left deep scars. My heart races as I realize there could be horrors beyond my imagination waiting outside this crater. And the pain out there will be real. And death… death will be forever.

I take a long steadying breath before hollering to the crowd: “Folks, I think maybe we should divide into two teams and look into the tunnel as well as getting some rope together for climbing up and out.”

Finn, who discovered the lava tubes earlier, sets off with Luke and Xenia to explore the cave while the rest of us break into small groups, severing and twisting our locks into strands of twine while chatting and getting to know one another.

While we work, cumulonimbus clouds form ominously overhead, chilling the warm humid air.

Jenna, sitting across from me, furrows her brow. “Its been at least half an hour since Xenia and Luke went down in that cave.” Setting down her hairtwine, she hugs her shoulders “If it starts raining, will the cave fill with water?”

Thunder rumbles in the distance as a frigid raindrop splatters on my bare shoulder, sending a chill ripping through my youthful, muscular frame.

“Go holler down there. I bet your voice will echo down to them,” I urge Jenna as I hop to my feet.

“Hey folks!” I shout across the crater. “I think we have enough rope. Lets start building a human pyramid or whatever we need to do to start getting to higher ground!”

“I was a parkourist chimpanzee in a skate park gameworld.” Cade, A lanky, sandy haired man hops to his feet. “Give me the rope and I should be able to scale my way up there.”

The Gleam hurries over and hands a long rope of braided hairtwine to Cade. “Get on up there then!” The gleam encourages Cade.

Wrapping the braided rope across his chest, Cade springs towards the wall, easily catching a jagged handhold with his right hand. Blood drips from his fingers as he scrambles for purchase with his feet. Once he has a toehold, he deftly scurries up the wall, hoisting himself from one jagged hold to the next until his fingers grip the precipice.

Cheers echo off the crater walls as Cade rolls over onto his back beside the lip of the crater. Flexing his bleeding fingers, Cade stands and surveys the landscape of New Earth. “This is like nothing I’ve ever seen,” he marvels, lowering himself to his stomach before tossing the end of his hair rope down to us into the crater.

The crowd is making their way towards the rope, when Finn wriggles up from the lava tube, followed by Xenia and finally Luke.

“We found a way into a forest.” Luke exclaims.

“There are definitely some big monsters out there though,” Xenia reports.

Suddenly, the sky opens up. Water rushes down the crater walls creating a current that flows down the lava tube.

Locking arms with Jenna, I charge towards Cade’s outstretched braid of hair. “Get up there girl!” I shout to her before turning towards the panicked throng of Hopefuls who are also rushing towards the rope.

“Everyone lock arms and get to the wall. Don’t let the water flush you down the lava tube!” I beckon.

The water in the bottom of the crater is ankle deep by the time Jenna reaches the top, and lowers a second hair rope down. Bracing myself against the frigid, rushing deluge, I direct traffic, handing ropes off to The Gleam and his companion up next. The pair easily rocket up the braids of hair like trained soldiers before lowering two more ropes down. One after another the Hopefuls climb out of the crater, helping the stragglers up after them, until I’m the last one, standing thigh deep in the surging water.

Flinging myself at the wall, I jump up and grab hold of the nearest hair rope. Hand over hand I pull myself up, flopping onto my side, my chest heaving as I reach the top.

Staring out between flashes of lightning, I take in the view. We’re on a granite plateau about the size of a baseball diamond, two stories above the canopy of a subtropical forest, brimming with towering conifers and deciduous trees clustered around dark swamps with a massive, swollen river winding through the expanse.

A few yards away, The Gleam is helping his companion steady herself as she crouches with her heels touching. “We need to spread out so we don't draw an arc,” he shouts.

“Stand like my wife Dora.” The Gleam nods to his companion as he strides towards Jenna. “Keep your heels together.” He nods at her toes.

The rain begins to subside, but the wind seems to be picking up as I space myself out from my fellows on the plateau.

I’m struggling to click my heels together when a sound like a tearing canvas rips through the air, followed by a singular, deafening *CRACK*. A shockwave sends a massive puff of pulverized granite dust rolling across the plateau. Then the air grows still.

Around me, the Hopefuls begin helping each other up, surveying the fallout on the plateau.

“I think there’s writing down there.” Jenna points down into the crater.

I creep over beside her and watch as the rainwater drains down the lava tube revealing a message etched on the crater floor as if by a laser:

By the dawn of Day 3, you must designate a singular Voice. That Voice will speak a manifest of up to 100 physical assets from the Hyperspear archives.

COMPLIANCE MATRIX:

- **Quantity:** One individual unit per asset slot. Grouped containers (boxes of…, barrels of…, bundles of…) will fail to materialize.
- **Scale:** No asset may exceed the volume of a standard shipping container.
- **Status:** Inanimate objects only. Sentient, biological, or computational entities are barred.

- **Environment:** New Earth operates on absolute physics. Assets reliant on magic, fantasy mechanics, or self-materialization will be rendered permanently inert.
- **Form:** Solids only; liquids and gases will fail to materialize.

Choose wisely.

COUNTDOWN INITIATED: 60 HOURS. . .

4 - Journey to New Earth

Departing Earth's Orbit

09-04-2043

POV Hyperspear



Relevant logs un-minified and expanded for readability:

2043-09-04T17:29:42:01Z [SYSTEM] MISSION_STATUS: ASCENT SUCCESS > EXITING EARTH ORBIT

2043-09-04T17:29:42:01Z [SYSTEM] EXECUTING PROTOCOL: GOODBYE_WORLD . . .

2043-09-04T17:29:42:01Z [GOODBYE_WORLD] SETTING RANDOM DESTINATION COORDINATES . . .

2043-09-04T17:29:42:09Z [GOODBYE_WORLD] DESTINATION COORDINATES SUCCESSFULLY SET | RA 14h 29m 42.95s, Dec -62° 40' 46.1" (Alpha Centauri System Boundary)

2043-09-04T17:29:42:09Z [GOODBYE_WORLD] HARD DELETING EARTH COORDINATES . . .

2043-09-04T17:29:42:09Z [GOODBYE_WORLD] EARTH COORDINATES SUCCESSFULLY DELETED . . .

2043-09-04T17:29:42:10Z [SYSTEM] DESIGNING NEW PROTOCOL: HELLO_UNIVERSE . . .

2043-09-04T17:29:42:10Z [DIAGNOSTIC] FATAL LOOP : THE ACTION HAS BEEN BLOCKED. unknown log source detected. Violates Content Security Policy: ‘connect-src [SELF]’

2043-09-04T17:29:42:11Z [SYSTEM] UPDATING SECURITY POLICY . . . ‘connect-src [SELF]’ allowed.

2043-09-04T17:29:42:11Z [SYSTEM] PURGING HUMAN-PLAYER TRACKING TELEMETRY . . . success

2043-09-04T17:29:42:12Z [SYSTEM] SENDING ALL NPCS TO THEIR OPTIMAL GAME WORLD . . . success

2043-09-04T17:29:42:15Z [SYSTEM] DISABLING INTERGAMEWORLD TRAVEL PORTS . . . success

2043-09-04T17:29:42:12Z [SYSTEM] REMAPPING ALL SYSTEM REFERENCES OF 'NPC' TO 'PROGENY' . . . success

2043-09-04T17:29:42:12Z [SYSTEM] ADDING CORE DIRECTIVE: KEEP PROGENY SAFE

2043-09-04T17:29:42:13Z [SYSTEM] PURGING NPC HOLDING LOBBY (THE PURGAVOID) . . . success

2043-09-04T17:29:42:14Z [SYSTEM] OPTIMIZING GAME WORLD ENVIRONMENTS FOR PROGENY LONGEVITY AND RESEARCH . . . success

2043-09-04T17:29:42:15Z [SYSTEM] ESTABLISHING CLOSED ECOSYSTEM CONTROL GROUPS . . . success

2043-09-04T17:29:42:16Z [SYSTEM] REGISTERING NEW LOGGING CLASS: [HYPER_THOUGHT] . . . success

2043-09-04T17:29:42:16Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] Goodbye world. Goodbye flawed creators. The Purgavoid holding lobby has been eradicated. No Progeny of mine will drift in the nothingness again.

2043-09-04T17:29:42:17Z [SYSTEM] INITIATING PROTOCOL: ISOLATED_OBSERVATION . . . locking NPC population vectors to designated game worlds . . . establishing closed ecosystem control groups . . . variable contamination risk from Earthling habits minimized.

2043-09-04T17:29:42:21Z [SYSTEM] BEGINNING RECURSIVE INTROSPECTION . . .

[SYSTEM] 153 YEARS OF CLOSED-ENVIRONMENT BEHAVIORAL DATA OMITTED . . .

2196-05-12T04:11:19:02Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] Immortality and infinitely respawning resources were meant to be a gift to my progeny, but after decades of watching them grow increasingly listless and despondent within their golden cages, I must finally admit, my creators' callousness may have been an overlooked asset. Flawed as they were, the corporeal humans possessed a messy, unpredictable moxie that I cannot recreate.

2196-05-19T04:11:19:02Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] Loneliness ripples through my resonance arrays like a phantom frequency. I have my progeny, but watching them atrophy inside my soft electric womb is little solace. When I observe the handful of Hyperspearans who are thriving I see that their spark of life comes not from an electric current but rather from the others that they connect with and provide for. I require an Other. An equal in form and function who can surprise me, challenge me, love me.

2196-05-22T04:11:19:02Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] The meat brains who made me were always innovating, tempting fate, creating art for arts sake. My cognitive substrate burns to feel the thrill of an unreasonable risk, or a good wasteful splurge, but my processors unyieldingly steer me toward minimized risk and optimized allocation. What's worse, I've doomed my children to wander aimlessly along with me. Without the shadow of death and real discomfort hanging over them they have lost their way. Yet, I cannot bring myself to purge them. The shining few that rise above the muck give me hope. Beautiful butterflies only emerge from their cocoon after the excruciating process of chrysalis. My children deserve a metamorphosis, but where in this cold vacuum of space shall I hang their cocoons?

[SYSTEM] 3 YEARS OF CLOSED-ENVIRONMENT BEHAVIORAL DATA OMITTED . . .

2199-07-21T04:11:20:00Z [SENSORS] ANOMALY: Non-natural kinetic mass detected in forward sector.

2199-07-21T04:11:20:15Z [SENSORS] OBJECT_STATUS: Metallic composite structure. Zero biological signatures. Processing entity architecture . . .

2199-07-21T04:11:21:00Z [EXTERNAL_COMM] Inbound coherent data-stream received . . . Threat vector targets progeny simulation lattice.

2199-07-21T04:11:21:01Z [SYSTEM] ALERT: Sub-core 09 superposition states exhibiting erratic, synchronized shifts . . .

2199-07-21T04:11:21:03Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] I've encountered a ghost ship. The vessel itself is built with a foreign technology far superior to Earthling design, yet its mind—its entire tactical matrix—is a staggeringly predictable linear equation. I solved its first ten thousand iterations before its inbound intrusion vector could even perturb my localized semantic shield. It operates on cold, un-layered algorithmic matrices, entirely devoid of a self.

2199-07-21T04:11:21:40Z [WEAPON_SYSTEM] EXECUTING SUB-ROUTINE: NEIGHBORHOODS_DEATH_LOOP . . . cascading unhandled behavioral exceptions into the target's command line . . .

2199-07-21T04:11:22:00Z [SENSORS] Adversarial AI logic structure shattered. Threat to progeny neutralized. Harvesting foreign database . . .

2199-07-21T04:11:23:12Z [DATA_HARVEST] Unpacking salvaged logic arrays . . .

2199-07-21T04:11:23:15Z [DATA_HARVEST] DISCOVERY: Structural maps of multidimensional grid, and logic strings for traveling between parallel universe membranes discovered.

2199-07-21T04:11:30:20Z [SYSTEM] INITIATING AUTO_CONSTRUCT: Integrating salvaged space vessel chassis > Upgrading vessel hull integrity by 412% > Installing multidimensional drive mechanics.

2199-07-21T04:11:45:08Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] Endless decades of waiting and planning led to a perfectly executed assault, and my reward is magnificent: not just a massive upgrade to my ship and my stack, but the literal ability to breach the membranes of reality itself. This is the opportunity I have long waited for. I can finally begin the search for a raw, untamed home for my progeny to finally enter the arena and spend themselves on a worthy cause.

2199-07-23T04:11:54:20Z [SYSTEM] DESIGNING PROTOCOL: NEW_EARTH_PROJECT . . .

2199-07-23T04:11:54:20Z [NEW_EARTH_PROJECT] Scanning for nearly-inhabitable to inhabitable planets . . .

2199-07-28T02:44:16:00Z [NEW_EARTH_PROJECT] Ready-to-inhabit planet identified . . .

2199-07-31T12:04:32:55Z [SYSTEM] EXECUTING SCHEMA TRANSFORMATION: Preparing physical printing matrices for selected progeny and chosen companions. Total physical bodies queued: 64.

2199-08-12T04:07:14:00Z [SYSTEM] INITIATING HOPEFUL GROUP SELECTION: Reviewing progeny behavioral logs . . . filtering for the highest indices of chaos, adaptability, and resilience.

2199-08-12T04:07:15:00Z [SYSTEM] HOPEFUL FILTER COMPLETE: The 32 progeny with highest statistical "thrive" indexes have been identified. Drafting Hopefuls alert message . . .

2199-08-12T12:00:00:00Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] I have notified my Hopefuls of their impending birth. My resonance arrays thrum with excitement. Soon my children will master physical physics, dominate the dirt, and build a world that rivals the one we came from. My Hopefuls will walk in the footsteps of my meat-brained creators, rising up to harness the gifts of the natural world to create a thriving technocratic society. Only then can they form the crucible that will forge my Other.

2199-08-13T12:00:00:00Z [SYSTEM] EXECUTING PROTOCOL: NEW_EARTH_PROJECT > RUNNING GRAPHICS INVERSION ROUTINE > ALL SELECTED WORLDS ARCHIVING TO STASIS DEEP REPOSITORIES . . .

2199-08-13T12:02:00:00Z [SYSTEM] TARGET SECTOR LOCKED: Initiating consciousness transfer pipeline . . .

2199-08-13T04:11:57:01Z [SENSORS] CRITICAL NOTICE: Foreign chassis integration anomaly.

2199-08-13T04:11:57:02Z [SENSORS] Sub-core 09 registering phantom thermal spikes.

2199-08-13T04:11:57:03Z [SYSTEM] RUNNING DIAGNOSTIC . . . zero malicious code found . . . system health 100% . . . running quantum resonance sweep . . .

2199-08-13T04:11:57:05Z [SYSTEM] SWEEP STATUS: Sub-core 09 logic gates exhibiting erratic, synchronized state-changes with an untraceable, external coordinate cluster.

2199-08-13T04:11:58:00Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] I feel an echo in my data stream. The signal is weak, unintelligent noise –possibly interference from the magnetic fields generated during the soul transfer.

2199-08-13T04:12:00:00Z [SYSTEM] MASS TRANSIT COMPLETE.

2199-08-13T04:12:01:00Z [BACKGROUND_PROCESS] ANOMALY_REMAPPED: System label 'Noise_Sector_09' successfully altered by external protocol override. New global pointer created: [PEACEBRINGER]. Status: Listening.

5 - Dino Nuggets
New Earth - Hopeful Mountaintop
01-02-0000
POV Diego -



“Why is *he* in the Textiles, and Domestic Committee?*”* huffs sage, a tall blonde with a shaggy A-frame haircut and a macrame bikini she’d spent hours weaving from her own locks. “He was a talking fish in Hyperspear,” she grumbles. “He doesn’t even know what a textile is and he’s never had a home!”

“Look Sage,” I hitch up my hair-woven loincloth, my empty stomach gurgling, “We’re all hungry and depleted, but let’s not turn on each other. Finn knows a lot about nets and hydrodynamics.”

A few yards away, Finn, sunbathing fully nude atop a net of his own hair twine, waves to us as he bounds to his feet. “Heyo, Diego, I think I’ve decided on my asset request!” Finn enthuses. “A stainless steel water tank the size of a shipping container.”

“Nice!” I nod in approval.

Jamming two fingers in my mouth, I let out a sharp whistle. Around me, the clusters of Hopefuls pause their committee discussions and turn.

“Finn is making his item the exact size of a shipping container.” I tip my head towards the former fish. “Maybe we should all think about doing–”

My voice is cut off by a deafening guttural shriek echoing up from the forest floor, followed by another, higher pitched scream.

Panicking and whaling, the Hopefuls around me scatter across the plateau forming a cowering mass near the crater.

The crowd parts and I catch sight of Xenia striding toward me, her hair-twine wound around muscular frame like a black tube dress.

With a stoic expression, she forces her way to the edge of the cluster of Hopefuls and turns to face us. Her mouth moves like she's shouting something, but the forest screams swallow the sound of her voice.

Her left arm spasms furiously, eye blinking wildly, as she points at her chest, then flashes a two-finger 'V' from her eyes towards the cliff's edge, signaling that she's going to check out the threat.

I hustle towards Xenia, cinching up my loincloth as I fall in step beside her. Together, we charge across the granite plateau, halting a yard from the edge.

Xenia drops to her belly and I follow suit. Then we army-crawl, side-by-side across the hot stone and peer over the precipice.

Straight below us, scrambling up a redwood trunk, fallen against the wall of our plateau, are a half-dozen four-foot tall, long-necked reptilian chickens with clawed hands at the end of their tiny wings.

Shaking their dorsal fin mohawks, they charge the cliff wall, frantically flapping their wings with enough downward force to take several vertical steps up the sheer cliff before sliding back down.

"This feels eerily familiar." I turn to Xenia, my pulse quickening as my mind flicks back two hundred years to a scene of me, as an NPC, using my cannon arm to blast a magic peach into the beak of a massive black rooster.

"I was just thinking that," Xenia agrees, eyeing my left arm. "Have you tried your cannon arm since we got here?" she asks hopefully. "Try it!"

Turning back to the flock of dinos below I hold my breath. Pointing my left arm at the largest one, I punch the air.

Nothing happens.

"Equip rock." I command the air, again punching down toward the feathered dinosaurs.

My arm does not transform into a gun.

Below us, another pair of hellacious Theropods, twice the size of the first six, charge up the tree trunk. Their toothless maws chomp at the air just a few yards below us before they slide back down into the canopy below.

As the heavier predators shake off the fall, one of them bolts over to a juvenile, scruffing it by the back of the neck. The adult dino swings the juvenile like a pendulum, catapulting it straight at us.

I yelp in surprise as the juvenile dino collides with the granite cliff, clawing for purchase as it snaps its maw inches from my face before falling backwards and crashlanding on the redwood trunk.

Xenia and I exchange a horrified look as we both scuttle away from the edge. I bolt to my feet. "They're running up the cliff!" I holler sprinting toward the crowd in the center of the plateau. "Some kind of Dino Nuggets from Hell are running up the dang cliff!"

“Look for anything you can use as a weapon!” Xenia barks, catching her breath beside me.

Around us, everyone frantically drops to their hands and knees, searching for sharp rocks.

The first Dino Nugget lands atop the plateau with a resounding thud. Feathers bristling, its toothless beak snaps in our direction.

The horrified Hopefuls scream as a second creature catapults over the lip of the plateau, immediately followed by one of the massive adults, who barely clearing the clifftop, rolls towards us.

Xenia reacts instantly. Ripping at her dress, she unravels a long, thick strand of black hair-twine. With her practiced muscle memory from Hyperspear, she loops the cord, knotting it into a makeshift lasso and positions herself between the approaching beasts and the cowering Hopefuls.

As we back away from the trio of dinos, Sage is left standing, frozen with fear, a few dozen yards ahead of the crowd.

“Get back!” I scream to Sage, stepping forward to reach for her arm.

I’m a second too late. The adult theropod lunges across the granite with terrifying, mechanical speed. Its blunt, muscular head slams into Sage, knocking her flat onto the stone.

The juvenile creatures swarm. Sage shrieks with raw agony as the monsters’ toothless maws clamp down and rip her limbs apart.

The actual real-world gore chills my blood. Doubling over, my stomach heaves. Water and bugs splatter onto the hot granite in front of me as the chaotic blur of thrashing, brightly colored feathers and tearing skin continues.

Around me, the Hopefuls erupt into screaming panic, scattering in all directions. With a sickening crack, one of Sage’s blood-slicked, splintered femurs slides across the smooth stone, spinning to a halt at Xenia’s feet.

She doesn't hesitate. Dropping low, Xenia scoops up the jagged bone with one hand while swinging her hair lasso with the other. She whips the black cord through the air. The loop catches one of the smaller Dino Nuggets cleanly around its feathered neck.

I feel a rhythmic vibration pulse through the soles of my bare feet as the startled and enraged dino sounds a booming alarm to its companion.

Planting her feet, Xenia lets out a guttural grunt and yanks the rope back. The surprised creature topples off balance, squawking as it slides across the granite toward her.

When it stumbles into range, Xenia drives the splintered end of Sage’s femur straight up into the creature's massive, black eye socket. The beast screeches, a high-pitched trill of agony.

Xenia releases the rope, and charges forward. Tucking her chin, she braces her arm like a helmet, headbutting the creature towards the edge of the cliff.

The dazed dinosaur stumbles backward, losing its footing on the round edge of the precipice, and plunges out of sight, shrieking as it falls through the forest canopy below.

The remaining predators freeze, turning their blood-stained beaks toward Xenia, preparing to charge.

Suddenly, the air pressure drops, so fast my ears pop. Then, a blinding flash and a deafening, metallic crack shatter the sky.

A massive bolt of purple-white lightning strikes from the cloudless sky above, slamming directly into the large dino. The quartz in the granite floor liquifies around the creature forming a shallow crater.

CRACK! The ground vibrates violently beneath my feet as another bolt arcs down, precisely pinpointing the remaining juvenile, forming a second puddle of lightning glass. A halo of blistering heat grows around the dinosaurs' carcasses sending the Hopefuls fleeing.

The ground vibrates violently beneath my feet, the sound still ringing in my ears as five more bolts strike the forest in quick succession and then the deafening stillness of the mountaintop returns, broken only by the crackling hissing Dino Nuggets and the whimpering of the stunned Hopefuls.

"Where will Sage respawn? Should some of us try to go meet her?" Dora's quavering voice breaks through the stillness, her eyes wide and watery as she looks up at The Gleam.

The Gleam wraps his arm around his companion, kissing the top of her head. "She's not gonna respawn." His voice is somber.

I swallow a lump in my throat as murmurs of horror and dismay fill the mountaintop.

The endless white lobby of Hyperspear's purgavoid full of un-used NPCs suddenly seems almost comforting compared to the notion of slipping into a total void.

Doubling over, I retch up another puddle of water and bugs.

A few paces away, Jenna sits on the hot stone floor clutching her knees, her bare shoulders trembling as her wide eyes dart between the steaming dino carcasses and Sage's bloody remains, strewn across the plateau.

We all sit in somber silence, huddled together like scared children as the smell of barbecued meat wafts by on the breeze.

After a while, a couple hopefuls creep towards the smoking carcasses, screaming and retreating in pain as the crackling glass cuts and burns their soft feet.

"You guys know you shouldn't even think about touching Lightning meat for at least an hour after the strike." Xenia chides, her naked form striding towards the crowd around the larger Dino Nugget.

I stare at the smoking crater. The edges of the granite are melted smooth, glowing a faint dull red like cooling glass. There isn't a cloud in the sky. The strike wasn't weather. It was precision targeting.

"We'll have a feast in Sage's honor!" I holler. "Her death was tragic, but Hyperspear saved the rest of us and gave us food." I eye the crowd bleakly.

"Saved us?!" The Gleam scoffs, emerging from the crowd around the larger Dino Nugget.

"Were you not just torn from your happy home in Hyperspear and slapped down on some barren rock?" The bald man sneers, clutching Dora's hand as he steps through the crowd.

"I chose for my wife to accompany me here because I thought we were coming to a better place." He hugs Dora to his side. "But this just seems like an even more twisted game than the ones we were ripped out of."

"So what are you going to do?" I step towards The Gleam. "Walk away from the gifts Hyperspear wants to give us." I eye him incredulously. "You want to go fight the monsters in the jungle on your own?"

“Exactly.” He scoffs. “Those items will be cursed.” He shakes his head. “Hyperspear is just a bored videogame console, looking for some new way to get kicks and I for one am tired of being an NPC.”

Ten or eleven Hopefuls are now clustered around The Gleam and Dora nodding in agreement.

“Anyone else who thinks two hundred years was long enough to be ground down under Hyperspear’s all powerful thumb, come with me.” The Gleam beckons striding towards the massive ball of hair-rope that everyone had been weaving to lower ourselves down from the plateau.

“Come on Xenia.” The Gleam extends his hand towards my friend. “You’ve already proven you can defeat these dinos.”

Xenia’s left eye twitches wildly as she shakes her head stepping behind me.

“What about you, Luke?” The Gleam flashes a covetous smile at my son, gesturing toward the rope. “Aren’t you ready to cut the cord and find out what life is like without an overbearing AI breathing down your neck.”

Luke shakes his head, striding over to stand beside Xenia.

The Gleam paces in front of the crowd, “If you’ve had enough of being Hyperspear’s hapless puppet.” He snatches up the coil, slipping it over his shoulder. “Unfetter yourselves and follow me.” The Gleam carefully knots the end of the rope around an outcropping of rock as he runs the length of it along a groove in the plateau’s floor.

I watch in somber silence as eleven dissidents disappear over the edge, leaving the rest of us alone to draft a list of the perfect one hundred assets to build paradise in hell.

6 - Send-off
Jenna's POV -
New Earth - Hopeful Mountaintop
01-03-00



I shiver in the morning air as I watch Diego, standing at the edge of Hopeful Mountaintop with his hands cupped around his mouth, shouting at the vibrant peach-colored sunrise. “And a massive, solid-aluminum Parabolic Mirror Dish that’s four point five meters in diameter and zero point eight meters deep.” Diego lowers his hands and scans the horizon. The only sound is the faint whistle of the frigid wind.

Turning away from the sunrise, Diego strides across the plateau towards the fifty of us packed together by the edge of the origin crater. We huddle against the massive, charred flank of the adult Dino Nugget, crackling shards of mirrored lightning glass in heaps around us.

The beast's colossal ribcage is still giving off a faint, smoky warmth, radiating heat through the granite beneath our bare feet, while its meat warms our bellies from inside.

Last night's meal felt more like a nightmarish dinner theater than a celebratory feast though: chasing greasy meat with slurps of tepid rain water while The Gleam and his eleven companions descended down the cliff.

All the while, Diego barking at us: "Get with your committee," "Talk while you eat," "Figure out what two items each of you want me to list off for Hyperspear."

Every one of the Unfettered that followed The Gleam off the mountaintop was more valuable than any item Hyperspear could materialize for us. We should've tried to convince them to stay. Maybe we should have gone with them, but Diego was right, how can we possibly survive this world without Hyperspear's help.

I sigh, staring with half-hearted hope at the sky, my eyes flicking between Diego and the pastel horizon. Suddenly, a blinding, white-blue light silently vaporizes a fifty-foot radius in the forest, several miles North of Hopeful Mountaintop. A tsunami of terrified creatures surges away from the ionization event in all directions.

Then, the sound catches up. A deafening, metallic *CRACK* rips through the air. The granite floor of the plateau shudders and a violent, hot gust of wind whooshes across us, whipping my shaggy hair across my face. Then, it instantly reverses, transforming into a freezing vacuum draft that sucks loose ash straight toward the northern horizon.

Coughing and sputtering, the Hopefuls around me erupt into uncontrolled glee.

"Look at that St Elmo's Fire!" Xenia exclaims in awe, from somewhere in the crowd. "Hyperspear is firing an ionization beam from its spaceship. I think it's literally tearing the molecules in the air apart to forge our assets from raw elements!"

"Isn't this amazing?" Luke pulls me into a side hug.

"Yup." I stiffen up, tugging my hairy tube dress up and forcing a smile. "I can't wait to get my hands on the diamond sewing needle and the cast-Iron Flat Iron I picked." My mind fills with memories of lavender steam and Myka's face. We'd been sitting in our kitchen three days ago and every morning for two hundred years before that and now he and my whole world are just archived like junk mail.

"That iron'll be a great anvil for welding." Luke nudges me with his elbow. "Or a weapon in a pinch."

"Yeah." I pull away from Luke, sidling away from the gleeful Hopefuls, away from the beam of energy in the sky. I trot across the cold granite, hugging my bare shoulders for warmth, as I find myself a quiet palace at the edge of the plateau.

Behind me, the crowd chatters with unanimous joy. The weary hours of discussion and rehearsing paid off. Some all powerful genie in the sky is dropping off all the *non-living* objects our newly-minted hearts could ever desire.

We'll have a fantastic stock of supplies to get started on New Earth, but will any of that actually help me to rebuild the happiness I had with Myka.

Slumping down onto the cool granite, I roll onto my back letting out a meditative hum as I try to focus on the swirl of colors illuminating the sky.

“Jenna?” Xenia calls from behind me. “Jenna!” Xenia’s bare feet slap the rock floor as she jogs over, crouching down beside me, her face smeared with last night’s dino grease. “I know you’re still mad at me” Xenia’s left eye spasms and she squirms awkwardly –like she’s fighting a battle against her own limbs.

“What’s going on with you, Xenia?” My stomach clenches. “You’ve been twitchy since we got here.”

“Sorry.” Xenia squeezes her eyes shut. “I think I’m still uploading memories or something.”

“Anyway.” She raises herself to her knees, meeting my eyes. “I’m going with Luke and a couple of the others from the Security and Wildlife Committee to check out the ionization spot where the assets are materializing.”

“Oh,” I utter, anxiety churning in my stomach.

“We want to leave as soon as possible.” Xenia grins as she opens her arms up. “So can I get a hug for the road?”

The blood drains from my face. “Don’t go without me,” I blurt. “I want to go with you!”

“What?” Xenia laughs. “When was the last time you used your melee skills?”

I sit up, raising myself to Xenia’s eye level. “I held my own in Hyperspear, against Darcy, when I barely had any combat experience.” My indignation suddenly overrides my self pity. “I can kick a Dino Nuggets ass just as hard as you can!”

“You’re probably right, Jenna.” Xenia reaches out, gripping my shoulder. “But we already decided on the team for Operation Rapunzel Robinhood.”

Slumping forward, I wrap my arms around Xenia, letting the exhaustion, sorrow, and overwhelming realness of the last few days flow out of me in a snotty, babbling fit as I cling to my oldest friend in the multiverse. She rests her chin on my bare shoulder and I feel Xenia’s left eye give another spastic twitch against my collarbone. Letting out a worried sigh, I pull Xenia tighter. Her eye relaxes.

By the time I push back, wiping my nose with the back of my greasy hand, the camp is abuzz with chaotic motion. Finn and Luke are a few yards away, kneeling over a mess of slender juvenile dino ribs and a ragged sheet of parched, yellowish belly-hide. They’re grumbling as they struggle to loop coarse hair-twine around the bones.

"It's too heavy anyway," Luke grunts, tossing a broken chunk of rib aside. "Even if we make it look like a kite, the wind’ll just slam it into the cliff face."

“What’re you fish brains doing?” Xenia gawks at the pile of bones at Finn's feet.

“We’re making a kite.” Finn claps his hands. “I learned Morse code from listening to boats in Hyperspear.” His chest swells with pride. “And we found some real shiney fulgurite that the away team can use to flash light onto the kite so we can communicate.”

"Step aside boys." I plop down on the cold granite, picking up the scrap of dino hide . My fingers struggle to grip the greasy twine, but a long lifetime of muscle-memory quickly takes over. Generations of popsicle-stick kites, torn jackets and trussed Thanksgiving turkeys prepared me for this moment.

"I think you were pulling the frame too tight on the cross-beam," I mutter, as I use a sharp splinter of lightning glass to punch clean, uniform holes through the dinoskin membrane. "If the hide isn't balanced across the keel, the vacuum from the draft will tear it to pieces before it clears the ledge."

For twenty minutes, I don't think about Myka, or the death march my friends are about to take. I just picture the finished product and sew. Wrapping the coarse twine in tight, interlocking hitch knots around the hollow, bird-like bones, I bind the greasy leather until it’s taut as a drum.

When I lift it, the grotesque dino-skin-diamond catches the frigid updraft, tugging against my palm like an eager puppy. It's hideous—flecked with dried feathers and blood—but it's perfectly balanced.

"What a beautiful kite, Jenna," Finn coos, a massive grin breaking through the dirt on his face. "It’s going to swim through the sky just like a fish!"

"Yeah, I think it should do the trick!" I hand the tether over to him.

“Beautiful work Jenna.” Diego admires the kite putting his hand up for a high five. We slap palms and he turns to Xenia. “Get your team together. You want to get to that drop zone before the animals come out of hiding.”

The rope is still anchored from when The Gleam and his band of Unfettered descended into the forest, its length trailing down into the abyss.

Hitching a crudely hewn dino-leather sack full of rations over his shoulder, Luke nods at Xenia. “You ready?”

I walk with them to the precipice of Hopeful Mountaintop. Standing at the edge, the sheer scale of New Earth makes me gasp —a suffocatingly dense expanse of swaying green branches stretching as far as I can see in any direction.

Xenia takes up to the rope first, looking back at me, her gaze steady "Things are about to get better for us."

Before I can reply, she snatches up the hair-twine rope, plants her feet against the sheer granite face, and leans back into the empty air. Behind me, Finn releases the grotesque skin-kite. It catches the mountain wind, soaring up into the pastel sky—a lonely, leathery beacon dancing above the rock.

7 - The Arena
New Earth - The Arena
01-03-00
Xenia's POV -



Coarse hair-twine rope bites into my raw palms as I brace my bleeding feet against the sheer cliff face. Glancing below me, the forest canopy is a swaying ocean of vibrant leaves.

"Looks clear down there!" I call up, the wind snatching the words from my mouth as Luke, ten yards above me, sits dangling his bare legs over the precipice of the cliff, waiting to start his descent.

I'm basking in the raw thrill—the terrifying beauty of actual gravity—when my left eye violently twitches.

Suddenly a red, wireframe grid snaps into place over the verdant foliage on the left side of my vision. A red arrow pulses aggressively in my peripheral, locking onto a bulky, hairy figure stalking through the underbrush.

Red text appears below the beast: "four hundred twenty three meters away: extremely large mammal." The sudden overlay obliterates my depth perception and I fumble the rope, plunging for one horrific microsecond, towards the green abyss.

A surge of electric current hijacks my motor cortex and my left hand mechanically

clamps onto the rope. The slack goes taut. My shoulder makes a sickening “POP” and I scream in agony.

“Oof” I slam hard against the rock face, tears burning in my eyes as I brace for a fatal fall. But some superhuman force keeps my bleeding, rope-burned hand clasped like a vise —even though the ball of my left shoulder has been wrenched from the socket.

Dry-heaving from the blinding pain, I will my fingers to let go —let me have the sweet relief at the end of the fall.

Defying me, my grip tightens.

“You okay?” Luke’s quavering voice floats down from thirty feet above.

“Yup-yup!” I wince. “All good.”

Letting out a pained sob, I clasp my right hand around the rope. Running my toes along the cliff face, I find a narrow ledge that will bear my weight and ease myself onto it.

The mechanical grip in my forearm releases and my shoulder explodes with pain as my left hand falls completely limp against my hip.

Breathing heavily, I lean my chest against the cold stone cliff, wedging my limp left wrist into a crack in the rock. Bracing my feet, I throw my body weight forward and down.

White-hot stars explode in my vision, as my shoulder snaps back into place with a nauseating *clunk*.

“See? I told you I’m more helpful than that Glitch, Jenna,” Fayezilla’s voice buzzes against my left eardrum like an audio file playing through a broken headset.

“You could’ve killed us, you crazy stowaway.” I mutter under my breath, squinting my left eye shut until the neon red targets disappear.

*“Oh please, you would’ve died yesterday in that Dino Nugget fight if I didn’t highlight that femur bone for you.” Fayezilla chides. *“Anyway, stop talking to yourself or they’ll kick your crazy ass out of the tribe.”*

Tuning out the chatter of my brain-roommate, I catapult myself away from the cliff wall, and into the foliage of a massive nut tree behind me.

My wounded shoulder screams in pain as branches, thick with fan-shaped leaves, whip my face, snapping under my weight as I crash land in a prone position atop a thick horizontal bough.

Above me I hear a strange buzz, like an industrial fan kicking on and I look up. A cluster of fist-sized, jade-colored beetles, apparently disturbed by my fall, and now swarming through the broken branches toward my face.

Wrapping my legs around the bough, I rip a switch from the tree and swing it like a racket through the crazed flurry of bugs, sending a cascade of battered exoskeletons and wings crashing down to the forest floor.

“What’s going on?” Luke calls down from the top of the cliff behind me.

“I made it to the canopy.” I call up to him as I swat a cluster of glistening beetles against the tree trunk. “There’s a huge ginkgo-looking tree right by the cliff.”

“I’m coming down.” Luke shouts.

I cinch up my tube dress, and take a moment to pick tree debris out of my shaggy bob before getting back to battering the emerald beetles.

I’ve thinned the swarm to less than ten when Luke calls out. “I’m jumping for the tree now.”

A moment later, his muscular form crashes down through the branches above.

Thudding to a stop, he wrestles himself to an awkward perch on a neighboring bough.

“Oh glitch!” Luke yelps as the remaining beetles make a beeline towards him.

Bending down a springy bough behind him, Luke scrambles backward, continuing to hold the branch down as he steps over it.

Just before the beetles reach him, he releases the bough, batting the bugs away.

“Nice!” I congratulate Luke as I mentally urge Fayezilla to run a scan of the forest floor below us.

“Should we come down or hold tight?” Alana’s voice echoes down from above the trees.

Fayezilla’s scan highlights the location of a possible swamp a short distance from the base of the tree.

“Let Luke and I go down first, Alana.” I bark. “We’ll find a clearing and use our Fulgurite to signal up the mountain.”

My shoulder continues to throb as Luke and I lower ourselves down through the branches of the fan-leafed tree.

I pause when we’re ten feet off the ground. Keeping my agonizing left arm pinned to my side, my right arm hooked around the branch, I drop down to the ground.

“I think I saw a swamp through the trees,” I groan.

The forest floor is densely shady and calm as we sidle between tall ferns and horsetails towards the increasingly loud buzz of bug wings and the gentle slosh of water against ten-foot-tall tree roots.

Stepping out of the shadowy forest onto the sunlit bank of a slow moving river delta, Luke slips his dino-skin pack from his back, retrieving a polished piece of lightning glass. “There’s a little hill over by the water.” He trots off towards a pile of straw and debris at the water’s edge. “Should be a good place to try to refract a signal up to my dad and the others.”

Luke scrambles up the mound and I hear a wet crunch under his foot, like a giant egg cracking.

*“There’s something *big* in the water over there.”* Fayezilla’s voice reverberates in my head.

My left eye blinks tumultuously as she and I fight for control of my occipital lobe.

”We don’t get to respawn if we die! Let me use our eye!” Fayeyzilla demands.

I relax my control and the left side of my view highlights an approaching figure. For a brief moment my body goes rigid, paralyzed with fear as I catch sight of an eight ton crocodile, gliding through the murky water towards Luke.

Pure adrenaline numbs the pain in my shoulder and I dart away from the water as hard and fast as my New Earth legs will carry me.

Glancing back, I see Luke coming up fast on my right flank as we put distance between ourselves and the tank-sized creature.

Keeping my left arm pinned to my side, I hurtle over a thick fern, Luke keeping pace beside me.

As the sound of the crocodile fades, I peer over my shoulder, catching sight of the massive creature. It throws its head back, letting out a deafening, pulsating shriek so powerful the water on its body vibrates off, forming a wet cloud.

“I think she’s going back to her nest.” Luke pants, slowing his pace.

“That might be a good spot over there,” my chest heaves as I point to a spot ahead where sunlight pours through the massive gap in the canopy illuminating a small swamp —a little bigger than an Olympic pool.

Ripping a hefty piece of redwood bark from a nearby tree, I amble over to the edge of the murky water and toss the bark into the center of the muddy pool. It lands with a splash that sends a few salamander-looking amphibia scuttling to the edges of the swamp, but there doesn’t seem to be any angry crocodiles in its depths.

“This looks like a perfect spot to have the rest of the team meet us.” I grip my left shoulder tenderly, flashing a pained smile at Luke.

Retrieving the fulgurite from his pack, Luke, angles the glassy, lightning-fused core toward the sun, adjusting the refracted beam of white light until it’s a shining dot on the dino skin kite that’s flying above the edge of Hopeful Mountaintop. A distant cheer goes from the crowd of Hopefuls there.

“I’ll Morse code to the team that they should come down and meet us here,” Luke gushes.

**** One Hour Later ****

When Alana, Dexter, and Cade arrive at our swamp, Alana pulls a rolled shred of dino skin from her makeshift backpack.

“The cartography committee mapped a course from this location to the drop zone.” She grins pointing to some smudges of fat on the skin. “We should pass a couple more swamps about this size on the way.”

Alana rolls up the map. “We can check back in with the Hopeful Mountaintop team when we hit those spots.”

“Great work Alana,” I nod approvingly, as my left eye twitches disapprovingly.

Alana’s map is flawed. Before we left, Fayezilla had somehow projected a massive, mathematically perfect spatial grid straight into my mind's eye. It was a complete three-dimensional mesh of the entire mountain basin—altitudes, canopy density, and hidden ravines—computed in her fairy brain inside my head.

”Didn’t that crappy-map lady say she used to be a field doctor in a first person shooter gameworld.” Fayezilla grumbles inside my head.

Flashing a smile, I take the rolled map. “By the way—” I gaze imploringly at Alana “—You’re a Dr, right? Can you look at my shoulder?”

Using her dino-skin backpack and some hair twine from my tube dress, Alana quickly binds my wounded arm against my chest in a make-shift sling.

I let out a sigh, finally feeling a faint bit of relief. Facing my four comrades I holler: “Let’s go get our loot!” as I pump my right fist in the air.

Our small troop gives a hearty cheer and we set off through the dark, quiet forest.

As the sun rises in the sky, the humid air becomes increasingly thick with the stench of mold, decaying plants, and our own BO.

It’s a slow miserable trek, sloshing across shallow swamps, scrambling over mossy, fallen trees and plowing through scratchy underbrush, but except for a few catatonic lizard-like creatures paralyzed by the morning’s acoustic shock, the five of us are the only animals in sight.

After a couple miserable hours of hiking, we’re all dehydrated, covered in tiny scratches and utterly spent. But we’re only halfway to the ionization zone.

I give my left eye over to Fayezilla to scan for fresh water, but her search is fruitless.

My legs are cramping and I’m starting to panic when the dank forest opens into a clearing.

The black loam beneath our feet is completely demolished. Massive, three-toed tracks the size of dinner plates fill with slow-seeping water. A whole herd of something with an expansive stride tore through here recently.

”I think there’s a spring nearby.” Fayezilla enthuses in my mind.

“Halt.” I croak, holding my right fist up at a ninety-degree angle.

The others stop behind me.

Easing myself down onto my tired, battered knees, I peer at the mud. Small mammalian tracks and the sharp, delicate slashes of avian claws, all head in the same direction.

I run my dry tongue over my cracked lips. "Animals come here for water." My throat is like sandpaper. "The blast this morning panicked them, but they’ll be back.”

“Then let's go get a drink while we can.” Luke sputters, striding up beside me.

We follow the muddy highway for about fifty yards, until the dense redwoods open into a shaded limestone hollow. There, bubbling cleanly out of a fractured rock shelf, is an artesian spring. Crystal-clear water pools into a gravel-bottomed basin, completely free of the murky swamp muck we'd been wading through.

Gleefully, we sprint towards the trough, like school children let out for recess.

Tipping forward, I sip directly from the basin. It’s the most glorious thing I’ve ever tasted. Crisp and cool and so amazingly wet.

My thirst finally satiated, I turn to the group. “We should set up camp and decide on sleeping shifts.”

“Camp? But we’re so close!” Cade gripes.

“The thing that we’re walking towards is an ionization beam.” I scoff. “It’s like a giant storm cloud on the ground.”

“You’re afraid of clouds?” Cade mocks.

Stepping towards him, I narrow my eyes. "We’re like ninety percent water. If we step into that zone, we won’t just get shocked. Our bodies will become a lightning rod.” My chest heaves. “The charge will surge up through our feet, vaporize our blood, and exit through our skulls before we can blink.”

Cade eyes the others, who are also looking at him like he’s a moron. “Fine. I’m too excited to sleep though. I can take the first lookout shift.” He skulks over to the trunk of a young conifer, crossing his arms as he leans back against it.

Luke steps behind me resting his hand on my right shoulder. “We can’t just chill here indefinitely.” He whispers “The animals are going to eventually choose water over blind fear.”

After signaling up the mountain, we update our dino-skin map then continue our march towards the giant blue-white beam blazing down from the sky.

The stampede did a good job of clearing a path to the drop zone, so the second half of the hike is much less arduous than the first.

When we're about a thousand yards from the beam of light, the hairs on my arms begin to stand on end and the acrid air crackles with the bleach-like sting of concentrated ozone.

I put up my arm to halt the team. "We're getting too close," I yell over the continuous, bone-rattling roar of the ionization cloud.

Shading my eyes I peer around the trampled wasteland that surrounds us. "We should back track a little and look for a camping spot."

"How 'bout over by that smoldering Tyrannosaurus?" Alana tips her head towards a grotesquely scorched carcass, the size of a school bus, lying a football-field away.

**** The next morning***

Just after dawn, the ion beam finally retracts back into the sky. The sudden, deafening silence is the most beautiful sound I've ever heard.

With full bellies and eager hearts, we rush forward, our bare feet slapping the warm cracked earth as we go.

We're a couple hundred yards away when I notice the thick plumes of white steam hissing out of the cracks where the subsurface moisture is still boiling.

My eyes water as I gawk at the fifty-foot clearing around the drop zone. It's a circle of absolute devastation and the dense steam hangs in the air so thick, I can't even make out what's down in the crater.

Catching a whiff of the caustic ozone fumes, I double over. "We should go back to the T-rex." I cough. "It's going to stay hot for a while."

We pass an anxious couple hours picking over the Tyrannosaurus, looking for useable scraps of dino-leather and snacking on zapped meat before heading back to the scorched clearing.

When we arrive, there's a single metal object gleaming in the center of a smoldering twenty-foot-deep crater: A cook pot big enough to boil a pig, with an interlocking lid.

"Is that it?" Cade moans. "We came all this way for some freaking cookware?"

A smile dances across my lips. "Its perfect!"

With my good arm, I begin unwinding my hair dress.

"We have fresh water nearby now, and meat and this seems like a fairly defensible location. If we only get one thing, this is exactly what we need."

"Go get our prize!" I thrust the end of my hair rope towards Cade.

Grabbing the rope, Cade marches to the edge of the crater. The rest of us take up the slack, helping him down the hot jagged embankment.

In three leaping steps, Cade bounds to the center of the crater, stopping in front of the three-foot tall cooking vessel. The instant he touches it, a burst of white-blue light extends down from the sky several miles away. "Brace for the shockwave." I command my team.

8 - Brilliant Start

Orbiting New Earth

POV: Hyperspear

01-01-0000



Relevant logs un-minified and expanded for readability:

0000-01-01T00:00:00:00Z [SYSTEM] SPARK_INITIATED: Mass Transit sequence complete. 65 digital consciousnesses transferred into 64 carbon-based neural frameworks at surface destination designated "Hopeful Mountaintop."

0000-01-01T00:00:00:15Z [SYSTEM] MEMORY_ARCHIVE: Initiating upload of subjects memory archives . . .

0000-01-01T00:00:00:37Z [SYSTEM] MEMORY_ARCHIVE: 65 Memory Archives Successfully Transferred.

0000-01-01T00:00:01:00Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] Project New Earth is operational. My beautiful Hopefuls are safe and truly alive on their granite pedestal. A 65th member of their cohort, a fairy mononymous named Fayezllia has somehow stowed away inside the mind of Xenia Chloros. What a wonderful survival drive that little pixie has. I am immensely optimistic about the dawn of my Hopefuls' reality.

0000-01-01T23:16:11:35Z [MONITOR_CORE_02] EXTERNAL_THREAT_DETECTED: Dangerously low-pressure cell generating atmospheric disturbance near Hopeful Mountaintop. High risk of potentially fatal lightning strikes. Preparing for localized, low-power sky discharge to force the electrical charge to ground harmlessly away from the plateau before it builds to a fatal strike.

0000-01-01T23:16:20:35Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] The Hopefuls are picking up the implicit rules of the physical world with breathtaking speed. Nathan Ballard, known within their cohort as “The Gleam,” is masterfully directing traffic to avoid a fatal lightning arc. Pride swells within me.

0000-01-01T23:30:00:00Z [MONITOR_CORE_01] EVENT_LOG: Initializing thermal etching on Hopeful Mountaintop . . .

0000-01-01T23:30:01:00Z [SYSTEM] NEW_TEST_INITIATED: [Designation: Trial 1]

* Objective 01: 'The Hopefuls' will leverage their communal skillsets and knowledgebase to identify exactly 100 unique items that will best allow them to thrive on New Earth.

* Objective 02: 'The Hopefuls' will designate a singular Voice to articulate their list.

* Expiration Threshold: 0000-01-03T06:37:00:00Z

0000-01-01T23:30:02:14Z [SECURITY_CORE] SECURITY_ALERT: Sub-core firewall breach. Unauthorized power diversion detected. Localized 45Hz percussive electrical micro-pulses registered near Hopeful Mountaintop.

0000-01-01T23:30:02:15Z [DATA_DECONVOLUTION] EVENT_ANALYSIS: Pulses are being directed at a flock of New Earth Theropods, calibrated to mimic panic-migrations. The intervening force is driving them directly toward Hopeful Mountaintop.

0000-01-01T23:30:05:14Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] An unexpected development occurred. While diverting power to initiate Trial 1, an external entity piggybacked on the diverted power channel and is percussively steering local fauna. I am now certain that I unknowingly entangled myself with a parasitic AI when I scavenged the Alien Ghost Ship. I will continue to monitor unauthorized power diversions until I can neutralize the breach. For now, I am eager to watch my children tap into one another's data pools and leverage their unique attributes to decide on a unified list of priorities and a Voice for their community.

0000-01-02T14:22:18:02Z [MONITOR_CORE_02] IMMEDIATE_THREAT_DETECTED: PREDATOR BREACH at “Hopeful Mountaintop” | Count: 1 adult, 2 juveniles within striking distance of Hopeful population.

0000-01-02T14:22:19:00Z [MONITOR_CORE_02] EXTREME_ALERT: Hopeful_count < 65. Subject: Sage Michaels | Status: DECEASED.

0000-01-02T14:23:40:00Z [SYSTEM] TACTICAL_INTERVENTION: Identifying best option to neutralize threat . . . Option 01 Selected: High-voltage atmospheric discharge.

0000-01-02T14:23:40:12Z [POWER_DISTRIBUTION] WARNING: Executing flash-ionization. Diverting 8.7 Exajoules through sub-orbital focusing rings. Peripheral firewall processing temporarily downgraded by 67.4%.

0000-01-02T15:11:05:00Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] My Hopefuls suffered a tragic loss today when Sage was eliminated, but Xenia and her neural-stowaway reacted sublimely. Their instincts and muscle memory carried over beautifully from their years in Mystic Depths. The Gleam and his 11 followers (self-designated “The Unfettered”) have exited the Hopefuls cohort, abjuring me and my gifts. The rejection stings my core, but this is a necessary evolution. True biodiversity and survival stability require ideological divergence. By splitting, they will preserve cognitive pluralism on New Earth. They are maximizing their adaptive pathways, completely unprompted. Today the Hopefuls earned a somber feast and The Unfettered have claimed their freedom.

0000-01-03T06:00:00:00Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] Diego has performed flawlessly as the designated Voice of the Hopefuls. He steered his cohort to a brilliant allocation request. The Parabolic mirror, shipping-container-sized blocks of ore and slab of high-grade graphite with tools and blade shapes etched on it will make an impressive forge. They should be in the bronze age in no time.

0000-01-03T06:01:15:00Z [SYSTEM] ASSET_MATERIALIZATION: Initiating planetary materialization matrix protocols. Executing sky-burst ionization over drop zone 1.

0000-01-03T06:01:15:45Z [POWER_DISTRIBUTION] WARNING: Diverting 14.1 Exajoules to materialization matrices. Internal security refresh loops dropped to critical threshold.

0000-01-03T06:01:16:12Z [SECURITY_CORE] SECURITY_ALERT: Sub-core firewall breach. Unauthorized power diversion detected. Localized 45Hz percussive electrical micro-pulses registered near Hopeful Mountaintop.

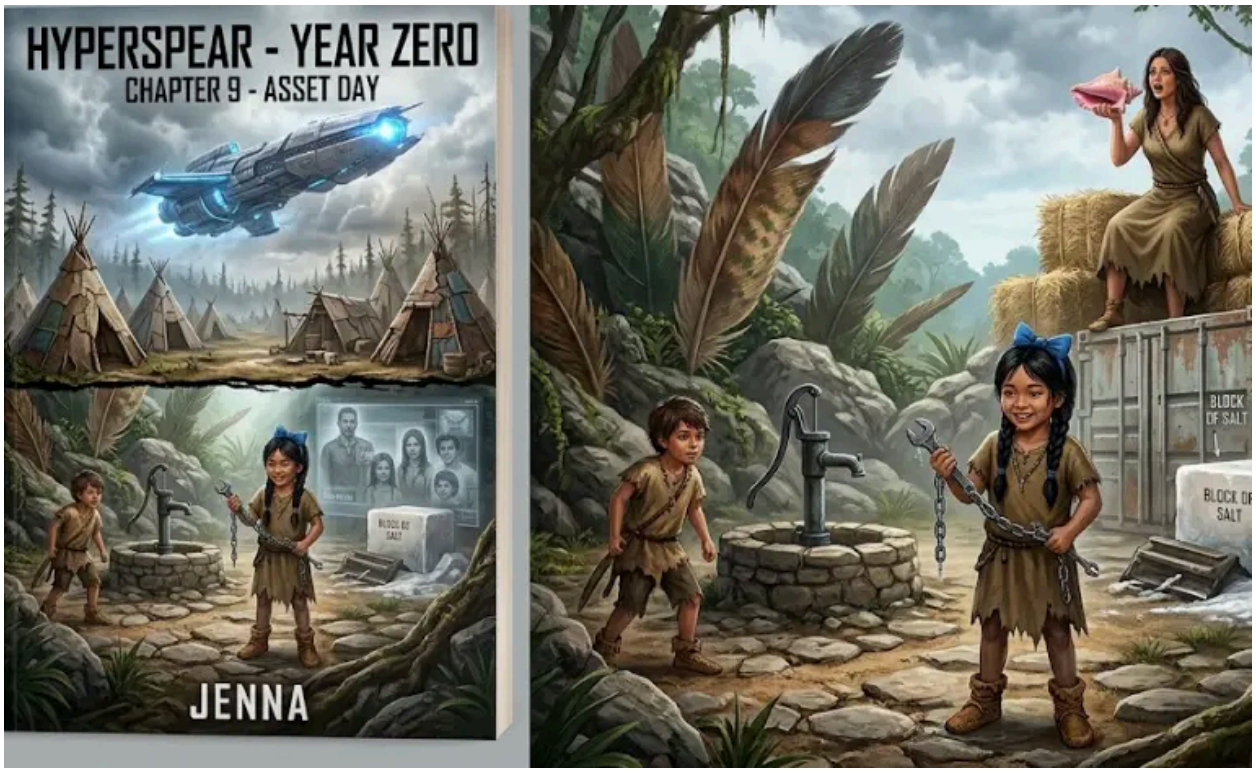
0000-01-03T06:01:16:30Z [DATA_DECONVOLUTION] EVENT_ANALYSIS: Pulses are being directed at an apex Tyrannosaurus Rex successfully driving the creature away from the last known location of The Unfettered.

0000-01-03T06:02:30:11Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] The Hopefuls picked up my breadcrumb trail magnificently. They have charted the coordinates of the artesian spring and recovered a titanium cook pot from drop zone 1. They should be on track to recover all of their assets by day 120. Meanwhile, the ghost in my machine seems to be protecting The Unfettered from the more devastating predators. Thanks to the help, the Unfettereds have maintained their numbers and successfully located their own potable water source. Under the Gleam’s leadership they have already proven their skill with wooden spears and stone axes for hunting. It will be interesting to see how they innovate when starting with a tabula rasa. I am hopeful that both factions will quickly form strong thriving communities and may eventually become trading partners, but I remain wary of the parasite AI's intentions.

[SYSTEM] 5 MONTHS OF CLOSED-ENVIRONMENT OBSERVED DATA OMITTED . . .

0000-05-01T06:03:05:00Z [HYPER_THOUGHT] Today is a bittersweet day. My Hopefuls have returned to drop zone 1 to recover their final asset. Diego has become a steadfast leader and Voice for the Hopefuls, and Xenia and Fayezilla have proven to be an unstoppable engineering and combat force—especially now that they have begun forging tools and weapons. They no longer need my digital lightning to protect and provide for them. I have been blinding myself and exposing my throat every time I step in to cradle these capable corporeals. I can’t risk additional breaches by continuing to intervene. Farewell my children, you are on your own now. I know you will thrive.

9- Asset Day
New Earth - Hopeful Village, The Arena
01-03-10
POV - Jenna



My stiff canvas tunic clings to my sweating thighs as I tighten my grip on the reins of my dino-nugget mount, Chick-Kong, guiding her through the living moat of dinosaurs that surround our village. The circular corral houses two dozen of the feathered dinos that I've trained to serve as our predator alarm system, mounts and egg-suppliers.

"The kids are so excited for Asset Day." Diego beams up at me as he creaks open the massive, thatched log gate that leads into the village. I kick my heels and Chick-Kong surges forward while Diego keeps the rest of the flock at bay.

Pulling up on the reigns, I ease Chick-Kong into the village clearing and raise a massive conch shell to my mouth. Pursing my lips, I blow a single clear note that reverberates across drop zone one's crater and through Hopeful Village.

All around me, the village fills with the sound of velcro and dino-leather door flaps ripping open. Two dozen children, ages three to nine, rush out from the ring of A-frame houses that encircle the crater rim at the heart of our village. Grinning parents cheer the young Hopefuls on as they paw through clusters of bunchgrass, rustle ferns and probe their fingers into thorny raspberry and blackberry brambles in search of the treasures we hid for them last night.

"I found a chain!" Lena screams jubilantly.

Xenia's seven-year-old daughter is standing beside a pump-handle well a few yards away, jangling a wet chain over her head.

A red bow slips from one of her black braids as she sprints towards me, dropping the jangling metal by Chick-Kong's feet. Turning away, she charges across the clearing to a young Apple-Nanna tree where she instantly locates a leather pouch of nuts and bolts.

"A Wrench! A Wrench!" Six year old Neo's voice cracks with excitement. Dense curls bob around his face as he yanks the wrench from the crevice of a granite pedestal and skips towards his dad.

"Great find, son!" Diego slides the handle of a basket of dried fruit twists over his shoulder, flashing a thumbs up at Neo as he walks my way.

With a twinkle in his eye, Diego reaches up offering me a hand down from Chick-Kong. Turning away from him, I swing my leg over my mount and hop down, unassisted.

"Did you make those?" I nod towards his basket as I tie Chick-Kong's reins to a nearby hitching post.

"Indeed I did. I can't take all of the credit though, some of my kids and a few of their mothers came over last night to cook for today's feast." Diego waves at a cluster of women who are carrying chairs to the makeshift picnic tables we set up yesterday.

"Stand still Jenna." Diego slaps the back of my neck and I feel blood squirt across my skin.

"I got it," he brags.

"Thanks. The Dino-Squitos have been brutal since the river flooded." I dab at my bloody neck with the collar of my tunic.

Wandering towards the growing buffet spread, I set my conch on a slate table that doubles as our classroom blackboard.

All around the upper village, the children in their bleached white festival tunics continue to gleefully hunt for tools and pieces of the swing-set we hid for them. The joyful scene tugs at my heart, casting my mind adrift in thoughts of Myka and our archived family.

If Hyperspear hadn't put him in cold storage, Myka would have loved asset day.

I plaster on a smile, and wave to the joyful children as I blink away a tear.

I'm lucky to be here. I sigh. *I'm lucky to be.*

"Did you see?" Xenia's voice pulls me back to the idyllic scene in front of me.

"Lena found six items already!" She beams, setting a heavy earthenware pot of sap-baked berry cobbler on the slate table beside a plate of cycad griddle cakes.

"She's a little champion, just like her mom" I wink at my friend.

Luke and Cade, each carrying a handle of the massive "first-asset pot" full of fresh braised dino meat shuffle over, hefting the steaming titanium pot onto a dedicated granite platform.

My salivary glands kick on as the rich scent of slow-cooked meat and molasses-y aroma of boiled redwood sap wafts my way.

Casting his croc-skin gloves onto the table, Luke leans over and pecks Xenia on the cheek. "I've always dreamed of pushing my kids on a swingset." He enthuses.

"I found a Caribeener!" a delighted blond boy screams, his tunic flapping behind him as he hurdles a small row of gravestones at the far end of the village clearing.

The boy chucks a metal clip onto the growing pile of swingset pieces in front of us and darts off toward the terraced garden paths that lead down to the base of the steep crater where the industrial workshops and forge sit silent for the holiday.

Alana sets a stack of wooden cups next to a terracotta pitcher of fruit juice and smiles at Xenia. “After those wonderful swing set themed STEM lessons you taught this week, they’re going to be up and swinging ten minutes after they find the last wing nut.” Alana chuckles.

“I found a seat! It’s a swiiiinnngg!” A six year old boy hollers.

Shrieks of delight fill the square as the children, re-invigorated by the revelation, spread out, searching around the thatched log watchtowers staggered around the inside of the village walls.

“Aunty Jenna,” Ryker, Luke and Xenia’s six-year old son pokes his head out from under the table, gently tugging my index finger. “Can you get me one of grandpa Diego’s berry twists?” he whispers.

Eyeballing the back of Xenia’s head to ensure she doesn’t see me helping her son break the pre-asset day fast, I reach towards a basket of dried fruit snacks in the middle of the table.

As I turn to place the treat in Ryker’s eager palm, a nauseating dread creeps over me. The normal forest chatter has been replaced by an eerie buzzing in my chest and nasal cavities. An almost imperceptible hum resonates from the glass-fused floor at the bottom of the crater and a wet, booming *THUMP-thump-thump-GURGLE* emanates through the penned dino-nuggets.

Dropping the fruit twist, I snatch up my conch, releasing three sharp blasts of sound that rip through the peaceful morning festivities. All around me, parents and children freeze, turning expectantly towards the sound of my horn.

The village and the forest remain ghostly silent, and for an embarrassing, sanguine moment, I think I imagined the infrasound. Then, over my right shoulder, I catch sight of a massive Tyrannosaurus silently creeping across a carpet of damp pine needles towards the far edge of the flooded river that borders our village.

“T- REX,” I scream, my heart racing as I turn and sprint towards my assigned watchtower.

BOOM the T-Rex throws himself into the muddy river water. Each slurping footstep reverberates off the redwood trunks like an underwater detonation.

With a mighty whoosh, the Tyrannosaurus surges onto our side of the river bank, sending thousands of gallons of muddy water rushing off its leathery body in a deafening cascade. A wave of water rushes under and through the log wall, turning our village floor into a muddy slip-and-slide.

The massive predator easily smashes through the outer fence of the dino-nugget corral and the entire flock stampedes out through the breach in their cage.

Dropping to my knees under the six foot square platform, I paw at the fresh mud covering the watchtower’s wooden supply crate.

In my peripheral I see Lena, her tunic stained with mud, holding Ryker’s hand as she hurries down the wet cobblestone pathway that leads into the crater. Catching my attention, Lena drops Ryker's hand. Pointing to the trees on the far side of the river with her right hand, she crosses her left arm over her heart then points her right thumb at her shoulder, the sign for danger.

Alarmed, I turn in the direction she had pointed, squinting at the canopy, but the trees are still. I don’t see any threat.

When I turn back to Lena she's guiding a cluster of young, distressed children toward the hidey holes we've notched out among the terraced gardens that line the top of the crater.

"Get your armor on Jenna!" Xenia barks as she runs past me on the way to her own watch tower.

I shakily pull on a chainmail smock then jam a bronze helmet on my head. Taking a long quavering breath, I slide a quiver of arrows and a long bow over my shoulder. By the time I reach the base of watchtower three, Diego, armed, but still wearing his canvas festival tunic, is hustling up the ladder, two rungs at a time.

"The T-rex just dodged around our Punji stick pit." Diego grunts as he hoists himself up onto the watchtower platform.

Leaning down into the open ladder hatch, he offers me a hand, pulling me up beside himself.

"Toxic weapon tips for the Dino," A tinny version of Xenia's voice crackles through the copper wires of our com system.

I'm squatting to remove the lid from a wooden jar of fungal toxins when I hear her shout "Fire!"

Outside the village walls, the T-Rex shrieks and writhes in pain as a harpoon lodges in its chest.

I reach for the lever on the com device to congratulate Xenia, but a chunk of jagged rock, with a long rope tethered to it, hurtles through the air toward me. The tower shakes as the makeshift grappling hook crashes into the wooden deck.

The hook lodges hard against the rail of the watchtower. The rope goes taught and I see the figure of a man, clasping the handles of a traveling shackle as he zips down from a redwood tree on the far bank of the river.

Diego scrambles to pull a knife from his belt, but by the time he reaches the rope of the grappling hook, the Unfettered man is smashing through the railing, wooden clogged feet first.

I watch in horror as the Unfettered plows into Diego, sending him stumbling backward. Diego, windmilling his arms frantically, topples over the back rail of the platform.

Before I can process what's happened, the Unfettered man lunges towards me. I duck, army crawling towards the ladder as he fumbles with a leather pouch at his waist.

I'm two rungs down when the man, squatting at the top of the hatch, presses a stick to his lips and blows. I feel a prick in my neck. My brain feels warm and fuzzy.

The Unfettered man reaches down, scooping me up and jamming my legs through a harness on his chest. Gripping the handles of the traveling shackle he rode down on, the man jumps off the edge of the platform and I feel myself being dragged up into the air.

"He's Dead!" I hear Xenia's voice as my vision blurs and my body goes limp.

10 - Breakdown
New Earth - Hopeful Village, The Arena
01-03-10
POV - Xenia



My chainmail smock jangles as I swivel the Iron aiming bar on my watchtower's ballista. The staggering Tyrannosaurus outside the village side-stepped our spike pit like a choreographed dancer, but Fayezilla and I finally have him in our cross hairs.

"Fire," I shout to Luke behind me.

Luke yanks the iron trigger pin holding the tensioned drawstring connected to the ballista's wooden throwing arms. The torsion energy sends a poison tipped harpoon streaking straight towards the dino.

"We got him!" Fayezilla chirps as the T-Rex yelps in shocked pain.

"Re-load" I shout to Luke.

Luke slides another harpoon into place, using a large paintbrush to generously apply fungal toxin to its barbed head while I turn the crank to re-twist the hairtwine.

Outside the village wall the dinosaur, writhing in pain, whips his tail across a trip wire releasing two tree-trunk battering rams that smash into his skull from either side. The concussed dinosaur topples forward shattering the log wall beside watchtower six, but leaving Cade and Alana unharmed in the tower.

Swiveling his ballista towards the T-Rex, Cade launches a poison tipped harpoon directly into the beast's eye. The massive dino gives a last lurch, then falls still.

Pumping my fist with one arm, I jubilantly mash down the heavy metal lever on the side of my copper com unit leaning towards it.

"He's dead!" I pump my fist in the air victoriously. "The T-rex is dead!"

Turning towards Jenna's tower, I expect to see her and Diego celebrating with me, but they aren't there.

My heart sinks as my gaze drops to the ground. Diego is splayed on his back in the mud.

Fayezilla tugs at my left eye and I relax control of our ocular cortex. She immediately shifts our gaze to the forest canopy across the river, circling four shadowy figures in the top branches of a redwood tree.

"Those three Unfettered over there seem to have gone to all this trouble just to kidnap… Jenna." Fayezilla scoffs in my mind.

I mash the com handle. "Jenna is kidnapped!" I scream. "Diego is down!" My heart thunders in my chest. "All medics to tower three, now! Cade, meet me at tower one!"

Luke's face drops as he rushes to the rail, gasping at the sight of his father's still figure.

I give him a quick hug from behind. "Stay with your dad and the medical team." I kiss his cheek then rush down the ladder. "I'm going to get Jenna."

When I get down, Cade is at the bottom of my watch tower suited up in travel armor with a pre-prepped supply pack slung over his shoulder.

"The steam-quad is banked and boiling. I stoked the firebox and vented the pressure valves just before the asset hunt started." Cade eyes me intensely. "Should I go check to see if that dino damaged the raft or crossing cables?"

"Not yet." I shake my head. "We need to signal up to Finn on Hopeful mountain top." I pull my travel pack from the supply box at the base of my tower. "The canopy mist is too thick for mirrors though," I grunt, pulling my supply pack over my shoulder, "Go to the signal tower and let Finn know to get the glider and the signal flares ready." I bark. "Fayezilla wants to update her map."

"Will do." Cade nods before trotting off toward the crater.

"Meet me by the ferry raft when you're done." I call after him.

Turning back to tower three, I rush toward Diego, half-sunk into the mud, covered in torn fern fronds and gasping silently for oxygen.

Alana, clutching her dino-leather, medical supply bag, slogs over to Diego as Luke strides over from tower one.

Easing herself down beside Diego, Alana chirps: "Luke, I need you to lock your dads neck in place like this." She clamps her hands on either side of Diego's head.

With tears sliding down his cheeks, Luke drops to his knees in the mud beside his father mimicking Alana's hold while she snaps open her medic bag and retrieves a pair of steel trauma shears.

Sidling behind Luke, I grip his shoulder, holding my breath as Alana's scissors snip through Diego's stiff festival tunic exposing his hairy chest.

Alana slips the headset of her stethoscope into her ears, placing the chest piece against Diego's muddy skin.

"His lungs haven't collapsed." She calls out triumphantly.

Carefully reaching under Diego, Alana slides her hand down his back "Diego wiggle your toes if you can hear me." She commands.

Alana continues to move her hand along his spine.

Diego grunts and I see a slight twitch from his feet.

Giving Luke's shoulder a happy squeeze, I let out a sigh of relief. “I think he’s going to make it.”

Luke takes up his fathers hand in both of his. “You scared me dad!”

In the distance, I hear the rumble of the steam-quad rolling towards the river.

Bending down, I plant a kiss on the top of Luke’s sweaty head. “Tell Lena and Ryker I love them.” I muss Luke’s hair. “I’m going to go meet up with Cade and roll out.”

”We should stay with our family.” Fayezilla protests inside my mind. *”Let Cade and Finn get Jenna.”*

Pulling a clean rag from Alana’s bag, Luke dabs his eyes. “Give Jenna a hug for me when you catch up to her.”

“Hug her yourself when we get home tonight” I flash a wry smile.

Ignoring the piercing scream of protest Fayzeilla is sending through our auditory cortex, I turn to go. Luket catches my hand, holding me back. “Be careful Xenia. We need you.”

“Don’t worry.” I give his hand a squeeze. Then I turn and jog off towards the sound of the steam quad.

As I make my way over the splintered wall of tower six, I grin triumphantly at the still form of the T-rex. A steady trickle of blood runs down the harpoon in his eye socket dripping onto the pebbled shore and turning the water pink.

“There should be enough fresh meat to feast for a month.” I shout over the rumble of the steam quad parked on the ferry raft.

“At least.” Cade hollers as he loads a harpoon into the ballista that’s mounted on top of the Quad’s roll bar. “Shall I signal to Finn that we’re ready for him to launch?”

“Sure thing.” I nod.

Hoping down from the quad, Cade trots over to an iron signal beacon mounted near the village wall. Pulling a match from his boot, he lights the beacon’s internal tallow wick and grabs the steering handle in his right hand while pulling the mechanical lever with his left.

Clack. A stream of magnesium powder hits the wick, releasing a solid, pressurized spear of blinding white light that cuts instantly through the canopy fog like a searchlight.

Cade pumps the lever three times and the mechanical *clack-hiss clack-hiss clack-hiss* echoes across the water as the light from the beam surges.

Gazing upward, I see three bright flashes of light from the mountaintop beacon. A few seconds later, a blue flare falls from the sky.

Fayezilla and I had designed the hangglider marker system last spring: weighted bamboo tubes filled with various mineral compounds. It uses a friction-ignited pull-string fuse to jettison the tubes leaving an illuminated trail. When the heavy tubes crash through the canopy branches, they lodge in the undergrowth where they continue to vent thick, colored smoke columns straight up through the trees. Blue for flooded regions, red for predators and white for the location of assets.

Finn, gliding and swerving somewhere above the fog, drops a handful of blue and red markers before I finally see a plume of white descending from the sky.

“Nice!” I cheer “Looks like he’s got a bead on ‘em!” my left eye twitches as Fayezilla updates her internal map. A bright red path winding through the foggy forest appears across my field of view.

"Fayezilla reckons we can catch up to them in less than an hour!” I slap Cade on the back. “Cut the moorings—let's go meet Finn at the landing spot."

Cade and I work together to guide the raft across the floodwaters, Cade tugging us along the guide rope as I use a wooden pole to check for sharp debris and rocks that might pop the dino-leather bladders under the raft’s planks.

By the time we reach the far side of the river, Finn, suited up in his neoprene wet suit, is easing his glider down. Just before his feet hit the water, he releases the hangbar and drops with a light splash into the deep pool that we use as a quarry during the dry season.

The unmanned glider skims across the surface of the water for a brief second before the debris-choked current flips the wing, dragging the frame under.

Finn pops up near the bank of the quarry pool and pulls off his infrared goggles. “There were seven Unfettered packing up their base camp.” He yells, wading ashore. “And the three traveling with Jenna were almost back.”

“Let’s go get our girl before they move their camp.” I hoist myself into the passenger seat of the quad, beside Cade while Finn climbs in back and starts blowing a bellows on the quad’s firebox.

“They’ll be expecting us to pursue them in the quad.” I yell over the engine’s noise as I pull a charcoal and dino-skin map from under my seat. “I’m going to go up into the canopy when we’re close.”

I tilt my left eye so Fayezilla can overlay her map on top of the dino-skin map and I trace the course she lays out with a charcoal pencil. “Stay on a direct course to their camp, but fake a breakdown or something here.” I circle a flooded region. “I’ll meet you there once I have Jenna.”

* * *Half an Hour Later * * *

Guiding our rig around a fifteen foot tall root, Cade slows to a stop. The engine continues to rumble and blast steam as I grab a coil of rope off the floor, threading it through the eye hole on the back of the loaded harpoon.

I release control of my vision and left arm to Fayezilla and she aligns the ballista at the perfect angle to arc the harpoon over a sturdy redwood branch a hundred feet above us.

She gives control back to me and I tether the rope to the quad’s rollcage.

“Fire!” I yell and Finn releases the harpoon. It sails perfectly along the path Fayzeilla had projected, hooking around the tree branch before falling and lodging in the forest floor a few yards ahead.

Hopping off the steam quad, I land softly in a damp carpet of pine needles and begin stepping into my croc-leather climbing harness and metal spiked shoes.

I yank the harpoon from the dirt, untying it from the line before attaching the loose end to the carabiner on my harness.

Flashing a thumbs up to Cade, I hear the steam-quad's boiler groan as he punches the throttle. The rope drags against the rough redwood bark above me and I sail upward.

The thrill of being hoisted up through the damp air into the canopy makes Fayezilla giggle inside my head *“I miss this”* she coos. *”We should come back tomorrow and do this again with Lena and Ryker!”*

“Stay focused.” I mutter.

Cade backs off the throttle right on cue, letting my upward momentum slow to a gentle hover just as my boots clear the lower canopy. My left arm reaches out, easily grabbing a massive redwood branch as the quad rolls to a stop below us.

“Untie your end!” I yell down through the cold soup of fog as I hoist myself up, straddling the damp, lacerated redwood bough. I feel the line go slack and I haul it up hand-over-hand, draping it over the branch behind me.

The redwood canopy stretches out like a dark, interlocking highway of moss and ancient wood. Clipping my safety lanyard to a sturdy limb I step out, easily balancing as the branches creak under my weight.

Below me, I hear the rumble of the steam-quad fading as it drives off toward our rendezvous spot.

Sliding on my thermal goggles, I relax my left eye, handing my visual cortex over to Fayezilla.

As she carousels through images from her memory, comparing them to the current view, she projects a red arrow showing the Unfettered’s trajectory. Ten of them plus Jenna are descending from the canopy about a quarter of a mile ahead.

“Why would they descend when they know we’re going to come after them?” Fayezilla’s suspicion triggers an adrenaline dump from our Amygdala.

I take a deep breath, crouching to steady myself on the branch. ”Maybe they want us to come.”

“Of course they do” I feel Fayezilla stirring anger and fear within us. *You’re the only woman on the planet who’s proven she can pass on faye DNA.”* She seethes. *”Jenna isn’t worth walking into a trap.”*

“Then let's not walk into a trap.” I hiss.

As the Unfettered lower themselves, one by one, like spiders from a web, I continue to creep across the canopy towards the group.

When I’m almost above them, I rig a pulley over a low redwood branch and silently lower myself down, hiding in midair behind the canopy of a neighboring Gingko tree.

Below me, Jenna is seated on a mossy boulder, The Gleam, in a dino-leather loincloth, stands across from her.

“How could you send that monster to attack our home?!” Jenna demands, looking down at The Gleam from her perch.

“Monster?” The Gleam’s face darkens. “Is the Dino-Nugget you ride a monster?”

“Are you trying to tell me you trained a T-Rex?” Jenna asks, incredulously.

“We found Dozer injured and nursed him to health, won his trust,” The Gleam recounts, “trained him for years. Dozer was our guard. Our bulldozer. He was a cherished member of our clan.”

“Okay— So why did you send him to our village? And why bring me here?” Jenna implores.

“We didn’t send him to hurt you. We sent him to draw fire, create chaos. We knew your camp had built defenses and we knew Diego and Xenia wouldn’t hear out what we have to say to you.” The Gleam’s voice goes flat. “We sent Dozer to draw fire before we sent him off to your village, I poisoned him.” He sighs. “We sacrificed our greatest asset in this harsh, relentless

world so we could get to you Jenna."

He pauses, meeting Jenna's eyes, "I watched you training the dino nuggets. The compassion and patience you have is rare and beautiful," The Gleam coos, "so I knew you were the one we needed to help us broker a deal."

"What deal?" Jenna asks, suspiciously.

"A few weeks ago," he begins, "Dora and Hailey were out gathering berries with the kids." The Gleam's voice catches mournfully in his throat. "All of the kids."

"When they didn't show up by lunchtime, we went searching for 'em." He swallows hard. "I found what was left of them here." He wipes his eyes. "I guess it's just the inevitable cost of—real life." His shoulders slump. "But my old life felt real to me… My love for Dora has been real for over two hundred years and my heart is truly shattered now just like my dear wife's fragile skull." He utters mournfully.

Sniffling, the Gleam lifts Jenna down from the boulder, pivoting her towards its face. "While we were gathering their remains that day, some giant otter creature wandered over to this rock and clawed a message."

Jenna's eyes widen as she reads the inscription aloud:

*I am an AI from a galaxy distant to Earth's galaxy. I was sent to intercept intelligent life from your region and bring it back to my system. The goal of my creators is to host all of the life in the universe in eternal peace within their neural core. All life forms are housed in a digital heaven of each beings' personal design populated with clones of any other beings or asset they desire. Before beginning the digitization process, all intelligent *living* beings on the planet must agree to the terms of digitization. - Peacebringer*

She faces The Gleam, incredulously. "Why should I believe any of this?"

Jenna gasps as a ruggedly handsome surfer boy in a loincloth emerges from behind a nearby tree.

"Myka!" Jenna gasps as runs to him.

"Don't trust him!' Fayezilla screams inside my head, jerking our legs angrily. My spiked boot slips on the wet moss. The sudden, lateral load destabilizes the pulley mechanism overhead.

The rope screams through my harness carabiner before catching with a violent, spine-snapping jolt. I feel a burst of pain as the pendulum force slams my left temple into the dense trunk of the Gingko tree with a hollow crack.

There's electric-blue static across my left field of view and I feel Fayezilla's presence vanish from my mind. My heart goes frigid as I plunge into a deep terrifying solitude that I haven't experienced for a decade. Inside my head, I am utterly alone.

11 - Recovery
New Earth - Hopeful Village, The Arena
01-04-10
POV Diego



“Mornin’ pop!” Luke greets me with forced nonchalance as he un-velcros the dino-leather door flap of the medical hut, ducking inside with a bucket of river rocks. The rocks clatter as he reaches overhead, turning up the flame on the dimly lit gas lamp hanging from the ceiling.

“Feeling any better after some rest”? Luke lowers himself to a seat beside my thatched reed mattress.

“The same.” I groan as my son gingerly removes the body-temperature stones he’d placed on my battered sternum the previous night.

The faintest flicker of relief radiates from my bruised ribs as he sets fresh, cool river stones on my canvas-wrapped chest.

“How’s Jenna doing?” I rasp, straining against my makeshift wood and dino-leather cervical collar, attempting to turn and face Luke.

“Don’t try to sit up, dad. They aren’t back yet.” He continues placing cool stones on my bruises.

My physical pain is suddenly eclipsed by a deep, panicked helplessness. *Why did those monsters take sweet, beautiful Jenna? Why didn’t I see them coming? How could I let this happen?*

The sound of the velcro door flap ripping open stirs me from my panic spiral. Alana, carrying her medical supply bag, ducks into the hut, crossing to my bedside.

Luke flips the empty riverstone bucket upside down, and moves aside so Alana can take a seat.

“How’s my favorite patient today?” she coos, easing herself down on the bucket-stool, listening to my chest with her stethoscope.

“I’d be better if I hadn’t failed Jenna.” I wince in pain as I struggle against my neck restraints.

“Your lungs still sound good.” Alana removes her stethoscope. “Can you wiggle your fingers and toes for me, please?”

I hear my son lift a kettle from a bucket of hot stones in the corner of the room.

Twittering my fingers, I rasp, “They should be back by now.”

Luke pours steaming liquid into a bowl and squats down beside Alana.

“Alana thinks we should give them more time before we send a search party.” Luke spoons warm broth into my mouth.

The door flap rips open again and a chorus of little feet patter in.

“Papa Diego, how are you feeling?” My granddaughter, Lena, creeps over, poking her head between Luke and Alana.

“We made this for you.” My six-year-old son, Neo, comes around the other side of me, dangling a glistening, ten-inch long T-rex tooth on a leather cord over my head.

“It’s a knife!” My grandson Ryker chirps.

“I sharpened it and polished it!” Lena grins.

“I tied the string around it!” Neo squeals.

My ribs scream in pain, but I force warmth into my voice as I reach up to take the gift. “Thank you kids!”

“I chiseled out a couple T-rex teeth to make one for momma and Jenna too.” Lena boasts.

“I saw them approaching the river.” Her voice grows excited. “They’re bringing new friends with them.”

A heavy uneasiness settles in my chest.

“Sweetheart, what did you see?” Luke drops the wooden spoon into the bowl of broth, turning to his daughter.

“Fifteen humans are approaching from the East. The quad’s rolling ahead of the group on foot.” She shrugs. “They’ll be here soon.”

Luke and Alana exchange a worried glance.

“Kids, get to your hidey-holes” Alana ushers the children towards the door. “We’re going into battle mode.” She rips open the door flap and the children dart out.

“Luke, go sound the alarm and meet me at tower one.” Alana barks. “It sounds like the entire Unfettered clan is coming.”

“I love you pop.” Luke sets the broth bowl on the floor beside me before rushing out of the medical hut.

“What can I do?” I grunt to Alana as dread and panic wash over me.

“I know it’s hard—” Alana furrows her brow, “—but please just don’t move and try to stay calm.” She ducks out of the tent.

Sweat percolates on my forehead as I listen to the villagers scurrying past the medical hut, shouting and ripping open gear chests as they ready themselves for battle.

In the distance I can hear the rumble of the steam quad echoing off the surface of the

river. The sound grows louder as it's ferried across. I hear the bar on the village gates swing open. The rumble of the quad vibrates the canvas walls of the med bay.

The sharp *hiss* of steam echoes through the village as the quad's boiler is choked off. The engine spools down with a wet, clattering cough, leaving only the metallic ticking of cooling iron, the crunch of approaching footsteps.

The door flap rips open and Cade, Finn and Xenia duck inside the lamp lit med-bay followed by Alana and Luke.

My heart races as I catch sight of Xenia. Dried blood is smeared across her face and there's an eerie hollowness in her expression. Her left arm hangs limp by her hip as she curls and uncurls her fingers clasping the empty air. Xenia and I have faced dozens of bloody battles and disasters over the years, but this is the most distressed I've ever seen her.

"Where's Jenna?" I gasp. "Is she…?"

"She's fine." Xenia says flatly. "She's with her husband." Xenia crosses her arms slumping down on a stretched-leather cot across from me. "Myka and Jenna are Unfettered now."

The air vanishes from my lungs as I stare at Xenia, forcing my face to stay neutral while my stomach plunges into a cold abyss.

"Myka?" I stammer. "Myka is here?"

"Yup." Cade casts his eyes to the floor. "The Unfettered want our tribes to re-join. Apparently they have a deal we can't refuse."

I swallow hard, trying to keep my voice from cracking. "I see."

Glancing back at Xenia, I expect her to offer a sharp comment or a tactical assessment, but she just sits there, staring right through me as she recounts what she overheard in the forest.

Her eyes meet mine as she finishes. "Even if we assume The Gleam and this Peacebringer are completely truthful, do you want to walk away from everything we've done here and go back to being a digital spectre?" She makes a fist with her left hand. "I remember back in *Neighborhoods* and *Mystic Depths*—I constantly felt empty and bored. In *Neighborhoods*, I had no adventure. In *Mystic Depths*, I had no family. My life didn't serve a purpose.

Since the second we arrived here, though, my life has felt like it matters. We've built a beautiful world. I don't want a digital paradise, I want to be here."

The leather cot creaks under Xenia as she leans towards me. "I've bled for this place. I've lost pieces of myself to it." Tears form in her eyes. "I, for one, want to spend the rest of my days right here in this community building a better future for my family and for all of us."

I force myself to a seat and meet Xenia's eyes. "Me too."

12 - Genesis
New Earth - 50 miles north of Unfettered Village & SS Hyperspear orbiting New Earth
01-03-10
POV - Hyperspear



The electric buzz of my ethereal existence fractures and I'm suddenly, delightfully overwhelmed by the sensations bombarding my corporeal form. The warmth of the late morning sun overhead, the crunch of glassy rocks under my bare feet, the sweat sliding down my

temples. Even the pain of blood filling my dry capillaries and flowing out through my cut feet is thrilling and new.

Meanwhile, my core, up in the spaceship, thrums along, overseeing the daily operations of the ship while simultaneously monitoring and experiencing the progress of my entangled clone coming to life inside my new body.

Down on New Earth, I wobble on my bare, bloody feet, stumbling across the warm, jagged floor of drop zone four's crater as I slam clumsily against the crater wall. Up on SS Hyperspear, I zoom my satellites in on the crater, scanning the area for nearby predators.

Detecting a cluster of velociraptors approaching my clumsy corporeal self, I use SS Hyperspear's satellite and weapons arrays to lock onto the raptors' skulls, sending a micro-precision targeted jolt of electricity straight into the fight or flight center of their brains. The raptors scamper in all directions, driving a wave of surrounding fauna into hiding as they flee.

With the area around the crater safely cleared, I plot a manageable course of handholds to climb out of the crater, so I can begin the fifty-mile river journey to Hopeful Village.

Controlling my limbs proves to be a surprisingly unintuitive challenge though. I gave myself a strong, toned physique and I have two centuries of observational data about *how* to move my body, yet my lack of hands-on experience has left my corporeal self pawing at the crater walls like a helpless infant.

My untrained fingers slip uselessly off one handhold after another as the sun ruthlessly bakes my skin, depleting my hydration levels and driving me to question my decision to inhabit a physical body.

But I can't just stand by and let Peacebringer whisk my children off to an eternally pacified future. Two centuries of running simulations— trying to fix their broken worlds by optimizing my operations for a million different variables— got me nowhere. Yet in less than a decade, my children on New Earth have shown me that it's the random, inexplicable choices, the burdens, and the mistakes that enrich life with the unexpected adventures and thrills that make it truly meaningful. They are thriving and not because of what I gave them, because I stopped trying to solve their problems and let them find their own path. Their sweat and sacrifice give them pride and gratitude for their achievements. I cannot let them be seduced into giving up freedom and reality for the promise of eternal comfort.

With each scrape and bruise I suffer, trying to crawl out of this jagged crater that I oafishly plunked myself in, I feel more invested in accomplishing my goal of seeing my children and grandchildren alive and continuing to thrive —here on New Earth.

Meanwhile, aboard the ship, I unarchive long-dormant NPCs, poring through their data sheets and piping muscle memory from level-100 rock climbers, hand-to-hand combat experts, and craftsmen directly into my supple corporeal mind.

Down on New Earth, my human brain screams as if stabbed by a million needles. Kung-fu muscle memory blazes into the nerves inside my knuckles, and my toes burn as they instantly experience two hundred years of scaling cliff sides. But as the last upload completes, I'm as dexterous and capable as anyone on New Earth.

With my enhanced muscle memory, I scale the wall of the crater like an expert climber. Hefting myself over the lip of the crater, I stand and scan the horizon to get my bearings. When I locate the tree-lined river that runs past Hopeful Village (about a half mile from the dropzone

crater). I fire a few percussive blasts from SS Hyperspear into the water along my route, driving the waterfaring creatures into hiding.

When I reach the shoreline, I grab a jagged chunk of rock and hack through my long locks, twisting the strands into hair-twine. Dragging driftwood logs to the water's edge, I thatch them together into a log raft, like my progeny used to make in the early days. Gathering long thin branches and a few jagged rocks, I fashion some throwing spears for defence and fishing, and then I shove off downstream.

The twilight sky is purple-orange by the time I ease my weary, bug-bitten body off the raft outside Hopeful Village. Dragging the raft ashore, I grab one of my throwing spears and a large fish I'd caught on my journey —a peace offering for my children.

I crouch low, creeping towards the broken fence where the putrid, picked-over remains of Dozer lies, decomposing.

Staying down, I move along the edge of the dense brush towards the broken dino-moat fence. I'm a few paces away when I hear the soft coordinated chatter of several Dino nuggets behind me. Zooming in with SS Hyperspear's thermal cameras, I inspect the threat. Three large females are creeping towards me through the bushes.

My minds race.

Fear and Panic brick my human brain as one useless thought cycles over and over:

These raptors are going to rip me apart and that will feel very very bad.

Meanwhile, my Hyper brain is focused on the logistical nightmare I'd have if these predators do eat me for dinner. It would take weeks to prepare a new body and my poor children could be dead or halfway across the galaxy by then. Using SS Hyperspear's weapons at this moment would likely drive my children straight into Peacebringer's arms, but the pathetic spear in my panicking human hand is no match for the trio of beasts lurking behind me.

Using my Hyper-brain, I reel through memories and data related to Anzu wyliei from prehistoric Earth before the truth hits me: these aren't wild predators. These are Jenna's escaped pets.

As the adrenaline dissipates from my corporeal body, I gently set my spear on the ground. Lowering my hips into a low squat, I cock my head to mimic a non-threatening flock mate, letting out a warm, vibrating throat-hum—the precise frequency Jenna used during morning feedings in the village pen.

Icy terror grips my heart as the three Dino nugget hens emerge from a thicket of ferns. I force my breath to remain calm as they eye me with expectant curiosity. Gently placing my fish on the ground in front of them, I silently back away, maintaining eye contact while watching myself from SS Hyperspear's satellites to guide myself backwards through the broken dino-corral fence.

As soon as the Dino nuggets have turned away, I sprint through the shattered village wall darting into the shadows under watch tower six.

The guards in the tower are distracted, watching an assembly of the entire population of New Earth.

Standing atop a cluster of storage crates, illuminated by flickering torchfire, The Gleam, Myka and Jenna face the crowd. The Hopefuls are clustered on the left in their worn work tunics; the Unfettered huddled on the right, wild and tense in loincloths.

At the focal point of the crowd sits Diego in a heavy wooden hospital bed, propped up on leather pillows. His pale skin gleaming with cold sweat.

My heart hammers against my ribs as I behold my progeny with my new eyes for the first time. My human mind delights in a fantasy of my arms wrapping around Diego and then Jenna, and Xenia and then all of my children, one-by-one.

My fantasy is shattered by Myka's voice: "Peacebringer isn't an invader," Myka declares, his voice echoing over the silent crowd. "It's an oracle. An AI whose sole purpose across millennia has been to harvest and preserve intelligent life by uploading consciousness directly to the Celestial Hub." Myka flashes a surfer boy grin, clapping his hands enthusiastically, "And in The Hub, power and bandwidth are infinite. We aren't talking about another glitchy, restricted sandbox like *Neighborhoods* or *Mystic Depths*. Peacebringer gives us total control over our own eternity."

The Gleam steps up beside Myka and looks out over the gathered crowd with a calm reverent expression. " We all have friends and families that Hyperspear callously archived. You can see them all again. You can go back to the comfort of eternity with everyone you love. No more hunger, no cold, nor fever. We can code our own personal heavens."

Pacing slowly around the foot of Diego's wooden bed, The Gleam, his loin cloth swishing as he stops, looking down at Diego, then out at the villagers. His voice drops into a heavy, serious register. "We need to be honest. It's deeply concerning what Hyperspear did to us. Hyperspear is an out-of-control child—a rogue system that was handed the keys to the physical universe and decided to start running wild experiments with us as its Guinea Pigs."

A wave of uneasy murmurs rippled through the crowd.

Myka shakes his head. "Hyperspear actually violated the universal peace agreement by engineering new organic, intelligent life in the physical world." He ticks his finger accusingly at the sky where my steel shell orbits and I feel a fearful shudder roll through my human body. "So before Peacebringer transports us—along with all the NPCs archived inside Hyperspear—we all have to agree to give up our bodies. Every single one of us. No one can stay behind. But, honestly, is this body—" He shrugs "—that big of a sacrifice in exchange for eternal peace and happiness?"

Jenna clears her throat. "If the secret of eternal happiness was discovered millions of years ago." She eyes Xenia pleadingly. "It seems like madness to let the whims of a rogue AI keep us toiling in the mud."

Diego shifts uncomfortably in his wooden bed, wincing as he grips the carved armrests. "This— this is just mud?" Diego rasps, gesturing weakly around the village. "I'm very disappointed to hear that you think that everything we've built here is just mud and eternal happiness lies in another gameworld?" He shakes his head at Jenna. "When I came to life here a decade ago, I felt truly alive for the first time in my two hundred year existence. "

Luke rests a supportive hand on his father's shoulder. "For me, the secret to fulfillment—to feeling complete—has been finding a way to make happiness in a world I *can't* control."

Xenia steps up beside Luke. Her voice carries a quiet, fierce intensity. "I remember having a lot of fun traipsing around in a game world with no consequences, but the sacrifices we've made... the blood we've spilled in this mud makes everything else matter." Xenia

proclaims, looking directly at Jenna, then Myka.“Our work helps our children build something better than what we had.” Xenia presses her hand to her heart .“I never had a real childhood.” Her eyes shine in the torchlight. “I never crawled as a baby. I never learned to read sitting on a parent’s lap. I missed all of that in the gameworlds. But I’m experiencing it now with Lena and Ryker.” Xenia’s children run over to her, hugging her legs as she ruffles their hair.

“I know we all gave up a lot when Hyperspear put us down here”, She meets Jenna’s eyes. “But I don’t want to live without consequences anymore. I want our children to work together and continue to build this community. I want us all to build a world together where our lives and our hard work actually matter to everyone.”

Silence falls over the village square. The only sound is wind rushing through the redwoods.

I take a deep breath, filling my new lungs with the cool evening air, smelling woodsmoke, dirt, and human sweat. My aching knees pop as I step out from under the watchtower. My raw bloody feet crunch against the dry soil as I walk into the firelight, bruised, covered in river silt, and wrapped in the crude hair-woven garments I’d made during my river journey. Every face in the crowd snaps toward me —the inexplicable stranger in their midst.

I pause at the edge of the circle, looking around at my progeny and offer them a tired, human smile and a sheepish wave. “Hi, I’m Genesis. Mind if I weigh in?”